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Master's thesis

Reconsidering Ethical Strategies for Reimagining Incarceration Narratives:

A reflexive and embodied exploration of the Digital Panopticon and Ironclad Sisterhood platforms



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Abstract

Introduction. This thesis draws on the concepts of animating the archive and contested heritage, exploring how complex archival materials are transformed into interpretive digital narratives and examining how digital heritage platforms ethically reimagine and present historical incarceration narratives. The study is situated within the field of digital humanities and engages critically with digital storytelling, representation, and ethics. Using two case studies—*Digital Panopticon* and *Ironclad Sisterhood*—the thesis investigates what alternative ethical strategies and challenges arise in the digital reimagining of complex incarceration narratives when analyzed through an embodied and reflexive approach.

Method. This study employs digital autoethnography to explore ethical considerations and challenges through reflective, embodied engagement with two digital platforms. This approach is complemented by semi-structured online interviews with two project scholars, offering discursive insights that enrich and support the autoethnographic analysis.

Analysis. The study analyzes and critiques assumptions of neutrality in digital representations through a Critical Digital Humanities lens, examining how affective experience, curatorial decision-making, and multimodal design either reinforce or challenge broader social and institutional power structures.

Results. The findings suggest that the act of reconstructing incarceration narratives within large digital archives can itself be understood as an ethical stance, one that fosters deeper emotional, reflective, and relational engagement with sensitive histories. Both of the analyzed projects demonstrated this potential to create affective, critical spaces for public engagement, while also revealing ongoing ethical tensions around categorisation, representation, and speculative narration.

Conclusion. This thesis concludes that embodied and reflexive approaches in studying digital heritage can enrich ethical practices in representing contested histories. It calls for continued attention to ethical digital representations of sensitive incarceration narratives by creating space for reflection, avoiding sensationalistic portrayals, acknowledging historical gaps, and maintaining transparency about narrative choices, methods, and emotional framing.

Key words

Digital humanities, historical incarceration narratives, animating the archive, embodied engagement, research ethics, contested cultural heritage.

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1 Introduction

The idea of cultural heritage has changed significantly since the 19th century; rather than seeing heritage as a static collection of the past, its construction can now be understood as an ongoing process and evolving discourse (Rouhani, 2023). By extension, digital heritage collections and platforms are more complex than a collection of digitized records and materials. This development has also brought a shift from the narrow focus on traditional, authorized heritage, such as grand monuments, notable events, and valuable artifacts, toward a broader exploration of its social and political significance. This shift has raised questions about the construction, remembrance, accessibility, and mediation of contested cultural heritage (Rouhani, 2023; Nilsson Stutz, 2023).

In turn, to move beyond traditional digitization, which has primarily focused on preservation and access, and address the challenges posed by institutional digital archives, which are often insufficient in engaging broader audiences or representing diverse perspectives (Glinka et al., 2015), the concept of *animating the archive* has emerged as a transformative approach to address these gaps (Schnapp, 2008; Dwyer & Davies, 2009; Burdick et al., 2012). Burdick et al. (2012) discuss how the field of digital humanities and "...digital toolkits and the expanded compass of humanistic scholarship provide some distinctive avenues for investing the present's stewardship of the past…hold out the promise of animating the archive." (p. 48). This approach, which views archival materials as active agents capable of telling new and alternative stories through interactive web technologies and enhanced methods for fostering experiential engagement with historical materials, has introduced new ways of engaging with both past and present (Schnapp, 2008). It offers innovative opportunities to reimagine historical lives and connect individuals with the past through dynamic narratives and multimodal engagements (Schnapp, 2008).

Over the past decade, the animation of prison archives and the presentation of historical prison records have significantly expanded, reshaping how we remember, access, and interpret imprisonment (Johnston et al., 2013). By integrating historical personal records, these animated archives create the potential for both academic and public audiences to gain a deeper understanding of historical incarcerated individual lives and experiences (Johnston et al., 2013). This potential, however, raises critical ethical questions (Godfrey et al., n.d.). Representing personal data and creating narratives involves choices that can either humanize or dehumanize, educate or sensationalize, and respect or exploit the integrity of those whose histories are being shared. While incarceration heritage platforms can make incarceration histories more accessible, they also risk oversimplifying complex lives or reinforcing dominant narratives if not handled responsibly. Furthermore, the user experiences created through digital elements such as reconstructed narratives, AI-generated images, recorded biographies, and other multimodal features introduce unique challenges in presenting sensitive personal histories in ways that balance engagement with ethical stewardship.

In response, this thesis examines how digital incarceration platforms and collections use personal historical records and archival research to reimagine and create

narratives responsibly to foster explorative and broader understandings of incarceration histories and material. By looking beyond questions surrounding legal regulations or open-access principles, this research focuses on alternative implementation strategies and ethical considerations, emphasizing emotional sensitivity and self-reflexivity in respectfully mediating and providing access to complex personal narratives of incarceration. It is done by means of a digital autoethnographical analysis of two digital projects—*the Digital Panopticon* and *Ironclad Sisterhood*—to study how my personal experiences and emotions as a digital humanities student and researcher are affected by how these platforms represent and present the lives of incarcerated individuals. The analysis focuses on how the narratives created by the two projects construct new meanings and whether these narratives respectfully portray the long-deceased individuals behind the records. To further address these challenges, this study incorporates an interview study, engaged by *disclosive ethics* and *goodwill ethics* (Proferes, 2020; Kelley, 2020), to gather insights from scholars directly involved in the analyzed projects and explore their approaches, challenges, and ethical considerations in animating historical incarceration archives. These qualitative methodologies were employed to further explore how the digital compositions and presentations of sensitive historical narratives affect the receiver of the information and how it can be shared and mediated ethically within digital spaces.

Thus, this study discusses alternative ethical strategies for animating historical incarceration narratives, emphasizing a person-centered historical praxis, based on empirical findings derived from an embodied and self-reflexive perspective, further enriched through conversations with scholars mentioned above, offering additional insights. The alternative ethical considerations discussed in this study aim to contribute to ongoing discussions about how to ethically and respectfully mediate and reimagine the personal life stories of individuals who once experienced incarceration.

The theoretical framework guiding this analysis is rooted in Critical Digital Humanities (Dobson, 2019; Berry, 2022; Viola, 2023) and research ethics in digital humanities to critically examine how digitally driven methods and platforms can facilitate the interpretation, representation, and dissemination of sensitive historical narratives. Within this theoretical framework, this thesis explores how digital heritage platforms can amplify incarceration narratives while critically reflecting on how such processes can perpetuate exclusions or misrepresentations if not ethically grounded.

The structure of the thesis following this introduction is followed by chapter 2, introducing the two digital projects analyzed in this study and providing broader discussions on research ethics, terminological choices, and the study's delimitations. Chapter 3 outlines relevant previous research, including literature on animating archives, representing contested heritage, and the ethical complexities of sharing historical narratives in digital spaces. Chapter 4 presents the theoretical basis, grounded in Critical Digital Humanities, discussing key concepts used throughout the analysis. Chapter 5 describes the purpose and aims of the thesis and outlines the methodological framework, including the use of digital autoethnography and online interviews, while also addressing key ethical considerations. Chapter 6 presents the

analysis and results, where the empirical findings are presented through a combination of personal engagement with the digital platforms and perspectives from scholarly interviews. Chapter 7 offers a discussion of the key findings, limitations, and broader implications of the research. Finally, Chapter 8 concludes the thesis by summarizing the study and proposing future directions for research into ethical digital representations of historical incarceration narratives.

2 Background

This chapter provides context for the study by introducing the digital projects analyzed in later sections. It also presents an overview of ethics and ethical research, followed by a discussion of the study's delimitations and the terminology used throughout the thesis.

2.1 Digital Panopticon

The *Digital Panopticon* project was launched in 2017 and published by the Digital Humanities Institute at the University of Sheffield. The platform provides access to millions of records drawn from approximately fifty datasets, documenting the lives of 90,000 individuals sentenced at the Old Bailey between 1780 and 1925 (*Digital Panopticon*, n.d.). Here, users can explore individual life archives, visualize historical data, and engage with broader themes of crime and criminal justice in the past. The project embodies the evolving role of digital archives in reshaping historical inquiry, employing multiple sources of information to offer a holistic view of crime and punishment.

This project is a collaboration between the Universities of Liverpool, Oxford, Sheffield, Sussex, and Tasmania, and is funded by the Arts and Humanities Research Council under its Digital Transformations theme. It presents how the digitization and analytical study of historical legal records, applying methods such as record linkage, data visualization, and computational text analysis, to reconstruct and animate the histories of incarcerated individuals. The *Digital Panopticon* employs a data-processing workflow that integrates sources such as trial records, prison registers, transportation documentation, and biometric data (including information on tattoos and occupations) (Howard, & McLaughlin, 2020). Through this platform, users can search and explore incarcerated individuals' lives through written biographies and interactive visualizations that display sentencing trends, transportation routes, and punishment outcomes. These tools provide new insights into the demographics of incarcerated individuals, including the role of class, gender, and geography in penal history. The database allows for searches based on names, crimes, trial outcomes, and specific tattoos.

The project leveraged pre-existing and created new datasets by connecting these fragmented records across different datasets. In its commitment to open science research, these datasets are made available under a Creative Commons license, ensuring that scholars, students, and the general public can engage with the materials freely. However, the project worked with data from commercial providers such as *Findmypast* and *Ancestry*. Despite their effort to make historical materials more widely available, full access to certain records remains behind a subscription-based paywall controlled by these commercial entities (Howard & McLaughlin, 2020).

I chose to analyze the *Digital Panopticon* for this study because it exemplifies how digital technologies can mediate personal historical prison records in a new way and how they can shape public access to and interpretations of incarcerated individuals'

lives. As a large-scale collaboration between academic and commercial entities, it reflects both the possibilities and limitations of digital humanities initiatives in engaging with complex and difficult histories. As an empirical example, the *Digital Panopticon* provides a case through which I can examine how a digital archive has reconstructed narratives of incarceration, what is or what is not included in the process, and how these histories are presented online today.

2.2 Ironclad Sisterhood

The *Ironclad Sisterhood* project is a collaborative research initiative dedicated to recovering and reimagining the lives of incarcerated women who were transported to New South Wales between 1788 to 1842 (*Ironclad Sisterhood*, n.d.). Initiated in 2022 by the Society of Australian Genealogists, it builds on the pioneering research of Jessie May Hill (1915-1995), former Assistant Honorary Research Secretary at the Society's library. Hill started to collect biographical information on incarcerated women sent to New South Wales in 1970, a time when both women's history and incarceration heritage were largely neglected in Australian historiography (*Ironclad Sisterhood*, n.d.). Hill indexed names, trial records, and personal histories on bank deposit slips, carrying her notes, whom she affectionately called "her girls", with her everywhere (*Ironclad Sisterhood*, n.d.). Over time, her collection became a valuable genealogical resource, laying the foundation for *Ironclad Sisterhood*. The digital public history project aims to make these records widely accessible while using contemporary digital tools to provide deeper insights into the experiences of incarcerated women. Today, the project incorporates a large searchable online database with 4700 scanned, transcribed, and structured entries available for public access (*Ironclad Sisterhood*, n.d.). To further the understanding of these lives, the project team has produced podcasts, sound-recorded biographies, and AI-generated images based on historical descriptions of the incarcerated individuals. Inspired by Saidiya Hartman's (2008) methodology of critical fabulation, the project combined archival research with fictional narration to reconstruct the untold stories from this history (*Ironclad Sisterhood*, n.d.).

Ironclad Sisterhood is an evolving project, aiming to integrate further archival sources, develop new historical insights, and expand public engagement. By collaborating with organizations like the Parramatta Female Factory Friends, the project seeks to broaden its impact and foster ongoing research into these lives. As a community-driven initiative, it continues to combine historical research with digital storytelling, ensuring that these overlooked voices are heard and remembered.

Although the project is not explicitly framed as a digital humanities project, its interdisciplinary approach makes it highly relevant to the field. By integrating archival research and digital storytelling, the project engages with digital humanities methodologies, especially in its use of digital tools to reconstruct and reinterpret historical narratives. I, therefore, chose to analyze *Ironclad Sisterhood* for this study because it demonstrates a narrative-driven approach to digital heritage, using storytelling and creative methods to recover the lives of incarcerated women. As an empirical example, *Ironclad Sisterhood* allowed me to explore how digital tools can

be used to creatively reimagine complex pasts, shaping how these histories are remembered and understood today.

2.3 Case study selection

The selection of the *Digital Panopticon* and *Ironclad Sisterhood* as case studies reflects two distinct approaches to narrating the histories of incarceration. The *Digital Panopticon* represents a large-scale, data-driven initiative emphasizing computational analysis and biographical fragments, using record linkage and visualizations to reconstruct personal incarceration histories from their archival datasets. In contrast, *Ironclad Sisterhood* combines data and narrative in a community-based framework, drawing on critical fabulation, using audio-based creative biographies, podcasts, and artificial intelligence-generated imagery to reimagine the lives of incarcerated women from their database through speculative and affective methods. While both projects aim to surface overlooked histories of incarcerated individuals, their contrasting narrative and technological strategies made them particularly fruitful to compare in order to explore how different modes of digital narrative mediation shape the experience and interpretation of engaging with personal incarceration histories. That is to say, their differing strategies offered a meaningful analysis for reflecting on how different approaches to presentation, affect, and access influence how historical incarceration narratives are remembered, felt, and ethically framed in digital contexts.

2.4 Ethics and ethical research

Ethics, also known as moral philosophy, can be defined as “the discipline concerned with what is morally good and bad and morally right and wrong” (Singer, 2025, para. 1), and can be understood as a branch of philosophy that explores principles of right and wrong conduct. Following this, research ethics refers to guidelines that promote integrity and responsible practices in the research process, as well as in the actions of researchers themselves (Severson, 2020; Östman & Turtiainen, 2016). In Severson's (2020) discussion about critical digital methods in ethical sampling strategies, she points out that “The implication is that the norms and values in new, digital tools are not as easily de-coded or understood without sincere reflection” (p. 82). In other words, when put into practice, research ethics involves not only asking relevant questions, choosing suitable methods and tools, and being mindful of context but also actively integrating ethical knowledge and considerations throughout the research process (Severson, 2020). Vulnerability or ethics of care is further highlighted by Severson (2020) as crucial to consider for minimizing harm, such as distress, exploitation, and misrepresentation, with emphasis on continuous ethical reflexivity through reflective and dialogical approaches as the field evolves.

Furthermore, Manžuch (2017), in her study of ethical issues in the digitization of cultural heritage, points out how important it is for memory institutions “...to make the ethical issues of digitization visible” to enable reflection on “...how ethical issues can influence the management of heritage digitization” (p. 2). This perspective is crucial because recognizing and addressing ethical concerns ensures

that cultural heritage digitization does not unintentionally misrepresent historical narratives and cultural identities. By making ethical issues visible and actively reflecting on their implications, memory institutions and interdisciplinary digital humanities projects can better manage initiatives of digitally sharing and representing historical research responsibly and inclusively. This could support respectful engagement and safeguard the integrity and authenticity of cultural heritage (Manžuch, 2017). However, as questioned by Richardson and Godfrey (2003) in their work examining ethical practices when using archived transcripted interviews, the ethical complexities surrounding the reuse of archived materials, especially those involving personal narratives, are often underestimated. Richardson and Godfrey (2003) critically reflect on how the posthumous use of personal information can be too easily dismissed as ethically unproblematic, noting how even scholars may view documents already in the public domain as detached from the individuals they represent. This perception can risk erasing the personal and human dimension of such materials when the individuals are deceased and can no longer voice consent or context (Richardson & Godfrey, 2003). Consequently, Richardson and Godfrey (2003) raises important questions about how researchers should ethically engage with archived content and recognize the subjectivity embedded in these narratives, regardless of their public accessibility and for "...social scientists and historians to develop and negotiate a shared ethical practice in the use of transcribed archived material" (p. 347).

However, discussing ethical terms rather than legal terms is a difficult task in the interdisciplinary field of digital humanities. Here, the scholars Östman and Turtiainen (2016) highlight how online-specific research ethics have become increasingly important as the field brings together researchers from diverse disciplinary and ethical backgrounds. They argue that in order to navigate this complexity, ethics should not only be viewed as a set of predefined rules but also as a reflexive and evolving process that is negotiated throughout the research lifecycle (Östman & Turtiainen, 2016). By advocating for self-reflexive methods, they emphasize the importance of equipping online researchers and students with tools to critically assess their positionality, methodological choices, and ethical assumptions in context (Östman & Turtiainen, 2016). This approach shifts the focus from only applying static ethical guidelines to actively researching how ethics are understood and applied in practice, enabling researchers and students to respond more thoughtfully to the unique challenges of digital environments. In doing so, Östman and Turtiainen (2016) underscore the need for adaptive, discipline-bridging ethical frameworks that recognize the situated nature of digital research and the fluid boundaries between public and private, human and data, and intention and interpretation.

As advanced technologies are increasingly combined with rapidly growing, high-resolution cultural heritage datasets, ethics and research ethics become even more crucial to ensure responsible data use, representation accuracy, and respectful engagement with digital cultural heritage. As discussed by the scholars from various disciplines and research perspectives above, looking beyond questions of how to

ethically manage and share data, alternative methods are now equally important to study and to embrace alternative ethical concerns in how digital cultural heritage and historical research can meaningfully engage with self-reflexive practices. In response to these concerns, this thesis focuses specifically on how integrating approaches that attend to the sensory and affective dimensions of human experience can critically explore ethical considerations in digital heritage work that reimagines historical narratives.

2.5 Delimitations

Following the discussion above, a key limitation of this study is that it does not focus on data privacy, as the subjects and historical materials accessed by these platforms concern individuals who lived over a century ago and are therefore not subject to contemporary privacy protections. While archival access laws vary by country, they often follow time-based restrictions on making historical records public. In Australia, the Archives Act 1983 generally restricts access to personal records for 30 years (The Australian Law Reform Commission, 2010), whereas the UK applies a standard closure period of 100 years for sensitive personal data under the Data Protection Act 2018 (The National Archives, 2021). While no legal barriers, in these cases, prevent the use and access of historical incarceration records, ethical considerations are still crucial in determining how these materials are represented in a digital context.

Furthermore, while this study is invested in ethical representation questions, it does not deeply engage with the technical aspects of data management, such as the findable, accessible, interoperable, and reusable (FAIR) principles, metadata standards, legalisations, or principles for open-access preservation, which are therefore outside the scope of this thesis. In other words, beyond the regulations of making data accessible, this study focuses on how context, emotion, and subjective experience also can be integral to data representation, particularly in relation to big data collections, where quantitative methodologies are often applied but may lack the nuance to study further how historical complexities and the ethical concerns in communicating these are applied. That said, this focus limits the scope of the ethical discussions in this study. It is, therefore, important to note that rather than offering a structured ethical framework for creating and sharing sensitive historical narratives, it instead challenges and rethinks how reimagined and reconstructed historical incarceration narratives are digitally and ethically presented and interpreted.

Another important aspect to mention is this study's focus on female incarceration narratives. This choice was intentionally made to seize the opportunity to contribute to and emphasize digital representations of historically underrepresented groups. Given that male perspectives and histories have historically dominated scholarship in historical research, this thesis purposefully centers on female narratives presented by the two projects, highlighting the often overlooked yet critically important history of female crime and punishment. While this focused approach may be perceived as a limitation, it is important to clarify that the study does not employ a feminist theoretical framework, nor does it aim to compare narratives, presentations, or experiences based on gender. Rather, the intention behind this selection is to shed

light on these marginalized narratives to broaden the scope of ethical digital representation within digital humanities scholarship.

2.6 Terminology

The term “incarcerated individuals” will be frequently used throughout this study. The choice of this terminology is reflected in the increasing support for “person-first” language, which seeks to humanize individuals within the criminal justice system and reduce the stigma associated with incarceration (Cox, 2020). This approach has gained traction over time, with activists and scholars challenging terms such as “inmate”, “convict”, “prisoner”, and “felon”, which have historically been used to define individuals solely by their legal status rather than their humanity (Cox, 2020; The Fortune Society, n.d.).

When searching through archives, historians and researchers often encounter these historical terms as they were used in their original contexts. Cox (2020) acknowledges the tension between historical accuracy and contemporary ethical considerations when engaging with archival materials. While it is important to recognize and analyze historical language within its context, modern scholars and archivists are also increasingly conscious of the impact of language and labels on current discourse. Thus, providing contextual notes or alternative terms when presenting historical materials has become crucial to ensure that the historical language does not reinforce outdated or stigmatizing narratives (Cox, 2020). Therefore, in this study, the deliberate use of “incarcerated individuals” aligns with the broader efforts to recognize the agency of those who have been in the criminal justice system while acknowledging the impact that language has on societal perceptions and policy reforms.

3 Previous research

This chapter presents an overview of scholarly understandings and research that informs the focus of this study. It explores how archives have been reimagined through digital practices, how difficult and contested histories are represented in digital spaces, and how ethical considerations shape the telling of others' stories in digital contexts.

3.1 Animating the archive

Animating the archive involves a set of different approaches, where researchers from various disciplines aim to make historical materials more accessible and engaging. Jeffery Schnapp (2008), former director of the Stanford Humanities Lab between 1999 and 2009, articulates how interactive web technologies offer new possibilities and challenges for institutions of memory such as archives, libraries, and museums to enhance and promote active engagement with the past. Traditionally, archives have functioned as static repositories of knowledge, preserving artifacts, texts, and records under restricted conditions (Schnapp, 2008). Thus, to bring archives to life, the growing field of digital humanities has introduced methodologies to engage the public and rethink traditional methods of conservation (Burdick et al., 2012). It encourages collaborative content creation, new curatorial approaches, and participatory platforms where communities can contribute to the curation and interpretation of archival materials (Burdick et al., 2012; Schnapp, 2008). By breaking down the barriers between professionals and the public, the archive can become a living entity that evolves through ongoing interaction and reinterpretation (Burdick et al., 2012). This shift moves beyond data retrieval and toward content reworking, where archives can serve as spaces for active learning and engagement rather than static collections.

Moreover, Burdick et al. (2012) argue that "...the "animation" of archives stands for a series of strategies for launching that afterlife from the very moment of archival processing."(p. 48), and to animate the archive implies a user-centered approach to build alternative ways to interact with the past. Here, digital technologies play a critical role in animating the archive. For example, Schnapp (2008) describes how virtual environments integrate archival content within digital spaces, allowing audiences to engage and experience history in alternative ways. Dwyer and Davies (2009) further explain the process of animating the archive from a cultural geographic, artistic, and virtual perspective and how these "...research practices seek, in different ways, to bring the material and documentary properties of archives into play, through an emphasis on bodily performance, the mobility of materials and the interplay between generating accounts and on-going processes of interpretation" (p. 3). From this perspective, digital archives can operate as platforms for experimentation, where users can reinterpret digitized historical documents.

Following this, Schnapp (2008) discusses how open-access digital platforms facilitate broader public interaction with archival materials. However, prioritizing openness, reuse, and reinterpretation raises significant ethical concerns (Bauer,

2023; Dwyer & Davies, 2009). One of the issues raised by online methods is the balance between accessibility and privacy, particularly regarding sensitive historical materials that contain personal information (Bauer, 2023). As Bauer (2023) highlights, unrestricted access to sensitive archival materials can risk reproducing the dynamics of exposure and control that these records often document. While they provide evidence of past injustices, they may also expose individuals or groups to unintended risks if made widely accessible (Bauer, 2023). As noted by Bauer (2023), "...this illustrates the question of whether or not a person should have the right to be forgotten" (p. 28). Additionally, Bauer (2023) argues that the digitization of archival materials collected under conditions of confidentiality poses ethical dilemmas, as records originally meant to be private may now become public, potentially harming individuals or their descendants. The lack of clear ethical frameworks governing the animation of cultural heritage adds to the complexity (Bauer, 2023). These concerns highlight the need for a careful balance between openness and responsible curation when animating archives. This is to ensure that ethical considerations guide the digital expansion of digital archives and their platforms while protecting the rights of individuals and communities represented within them (Champion, 2022).

3.2 Representing difficult histories and contested heritage

Throughout the late twentieth and early twenty-first centuries, cultural heritage has been actively curated to represent meaningful historical narratives, often driven by diverse groups seeking public recognition of their histories (Macdonald, 2009). However, some forms of heritage remain difficult and contested, challenging dominant narratives and raising questions about how societies combine uncomfortable pasts with contemporary identities, memory, and cultural preservation (Macdonald, 2009). A notable contribution to the examination of contested heritage is Sharon Macdonald's (2009) study of the city of Nuremberg's nazi past. Macdonald (2009) articulates how contested heritage "...may also be troublesome because it threatens to break through into the present in disruptive ways, opening up social divisions" (p. 1). In this way, the concept of contested cultural heritage, also known as "dark heritage", "difficult heritage", or "dissonant heritage", challenges practices of selection, preservation, comparison, and witnessing of the past (Macdonald, 2009; Axelsson Yngvéus et al., 2023). This is further discussed by Logan and Reeves (2008) in their examination of places of shame and pain, how today's societies have historical scars from involvement in war, unrest, and discriminatory ideologies, reflected in sites of violence, imprisonment, and forced isolation. These places, from genocide sites to asylums or prisons, can serve as reminders of past cruelty and misguided beliefs (Logan & Reeves, 2008). Yet, these scars and the history behind them are "...often eschewed in favour of narratives that contribute to the creation and maintenance of social or national identities in a more positive, progressive, way." (Benardou & Droumpouki, 2022, p. 1). For example, Benardou and Droumpouki (2022) point out how prisons and execution sites exemplify difficult heritage but are rarely embraced as valued heritage. Furthering this discussion, Tunbridge and Ashworth (1996) point out that dissonance is not an inherent quality of heritage itself but is shaped by social, political, and historical contexts. These sites and their history may provoke

discomfort and difficult or controversial memories, while others become sites of contested meaning due to how they are preserved, interpreted, or neglected (Tunbridge & Ashworth, 1996). That being said, the way these places and the history connected to them are presented and mediated plays a crucial role in shaping their significance and how they are perceived. This highlights the importance of ethical responsibility within digital and physical heritage projects in navigating the complexities of representing a complex side of history.

Following this discussion, the anthology *(Un)contested Heritage: Archives, Museums and Public Spaces* (Axelsson Yngvéus et al., 2023) examines how heritage is actively negotiated in archives, museums, and public spaces, with a focus on issues of power, inclusion, and the complexities of memory-making. Over the past two decades, the concept of contested and uncontested heritage has gained traction as scholars and practitioners critically examine how difficult histories are remembered, represented, and challenged within cultural institutions and public discourse. Axelsson Yngvéus et al. (2023), drawing on contributions from scholars across various disciplines, argue that by highlighting rather than minimizing the complexities and uncomfortable aspects of history, heritage work can foster a more nuanced and comprehensive understanding of the past. Although engaging with contested heritage can be emotionally challenging, such engagement is crucial in bringing attention to narratives of oppression and injustice, thus ensuring these histories and lived experiences remain visible and relevant in contemporary discourse (Thorell, 2018; Axelsson Yngvéus et al., 2023).

3.2.1 Incarcerated lives represented in the digital age

Representing what can be a painful past has evolved to engage scholars across various disciplines in developing digital collections and platforms that confront and reinterpret contested histories. Digital platforms such as the *Digital Panopticon* and *Ironclad Sisterhood* (see sections 2.1 and 2.2) exemplify how digital tools can reconstruct historical incarceration narratives by linking archival records, mapping life trajectories, and presenting these lived experiences in new ways. Similarly, projects like *The Proceedings of the Old Bailey* (2023) and *London Lives 1690-1800* (Hitchcock et al., 2018) demonstrate how digitization can highlight and inform historical justice systems by making trial records, court proceedings, and personal testimonies widely accessible. However, while technology has created new ways of engaging with incarceration narratives, scholars have critically examined the ethical and methodological challenges involved in presenting more sensitive records online. As mentioned by Bauer (2023), “With digitization this has changed, which also affects the ethics of public access, since there is a difference, for instance, between one researcher reading a private letter and millions of people accessing it online.” (p. 29). Building on this, Bruce-Lockhart and Akande (2024) argue that, on the one hand, these collections provide a more nuanced understanding of individuals incarcerated by the state, challenging stereotypes and offering insights into often-overlooked social groups, which can allow families to uncover forgotten histories of their relatives. On the other hand, such records were typically created, accessed, and disseminated without the consent of the individuals they document, meaning individuals who are no longer alive to take part in their portrayal or reclaim

agency over their histories (Bruce-Lockhart & Akande, 2024; Richardson & Godfrey, 2003). This lack of consent raises ethical challenges regarding the contemporary use and display of these materials and narratives in digital spaces where accessibility is vastly expanded.

Following this, Bruce-Lockhart and Akande (2024) have also discussed the potential of structural power imbalances present in digital collections regarding documenting marginalized populations in official records. Bruce-Lockhart and Akande (2024) argue that colonial prison archives, which were often created to serve state interests rather than preserve the voices of incarcerated individuals, require a methodological approach for a person-centered historical practice. They argue that "...while such records can provide valuable information, engagement with these documents needs to be grounded in recognition of their 'person-ness'" (Bruce-Lockhart & Akande, 2024, p. 184). In this case, researchers must actively examine the power dynamics that shaped the production of these records and seek new ways to ethically engage with them (Bruce-Lockhart & Akande, 2024). Unlike contemporary oral history projects where participants can actively shape their narratives, historical prison records often contain deeply personal information about individuals who never consented to their inclusion in public-facing archives (Bruce-Lockhart & Akande, 2024). These concerns are highly relevant in digital environments where increased accessibility may lead to misrepresentations, such as the re-stigmatization of incarcerated individuals or the appropriation of their histories without adequate contextualization. To mitigate these risks, Bruce-Lockhart and Akande (2024) advocate for research practices that prioritize ethical responsibility over unrestricted access, including the potential anonymization of records, contextual framing of sensitive materials, and engagement with descendant communities when possible.

Spillane (2024) furthers this discussion and points out the importance of giving way "...to promote a new kind of public memory" (p. 99). In the United States, the memorialization of incarceration has traditionally centered on the physical structures of prisons, with sites like Alcatraz and Eastern State Penitentiary becoming tourist attractions where the architecture comes before the experiences of those once confined within them (Spillane, 2024). However, alternative initiatives, such as the *Prison Public Memory Project* in New York and the *White House Boys* organization in Florida, challenge this approach by emphasizing the power of memory as an active, present-day process (Spillane, 2024). Spillane (2024) emphasizes that these projects focus on documenting the personal, non-anonymous experiences of incarcerated individuals, ensuring that their voices and histories remain central to the narrative. Thus, both Spillane (2024) and Bruce-Lockhart & Akande (2024) contribute to the critical discourse on digital archival practices in representing a person-centered perspective working with archival prison records. While their respective studies focus on different historical and geographic contexts, they collectively underscore the need for critical engagement with the ethical dimensions of representing incarcerated individuals' personal records. As previously discussed, the representation of incarcerated individuals in digital spaces is not a neutral act, it is indeed an interpretive endeavor that must pay close attention to the tensions between accessibility, historical accuracy, and respect for the dignity of those whose

lives are documented. As digital heritage projects continue to develop innovative approaches to animating prison archives, these ethical considerations remain central to ensuring that such representations are conducted responsibly and with a critical awareness of their broader implications.

3.3 Ethically sharing someone else's story

In her examination and development of a collaborative, community-based co-design course on interactive narrative design for cultural heritage, Rebecca Rouse (2019) explores the ethical challenges that arise when telling someone else's story. Rouse's (2019) case studies and discussions focus on the recognition that interactive narrative design and digital storytelling are not neutral acts, regardless of whether the individuals in question can consent or participate in the design process. Rather, implementing digital technologies, such as interactive platforms and media, has "...further impacts for representations of authenticity, voice, and power" (Rouse, 2019, p. 48). Rouse (2019) underscores that what may appear as a simple display of history is an inherently interpretive and selective act, shaped by the designers, curators, and institutions responsible for its mediation. Rouse (2019) writes that "...mere representation or increased visibility does not equate to power, and can in fact be a trap resulting in commodification and sublimation" (p. 49). Even when working with archival records from over a century ago, these ethical tensions remain relevant. The stories of historical individuals are subjected to modern frameworks of research, interpretation, and public display. Rouse (2019) suggests that co-creation design processes are key, urging practitioners and students to examine the power differentials inherent in the design and dissemination of difficult heritage. According to Rouse (2019), adopting a dialogic perspective, whereby designers acknowledge their own perspectives and biases, invite critique, and consult multiple stakeholder voices, can help mitigate exploitative or misrepresentations.

Furthermore, Rouse (2019) highlights that interactive or multimedia storytelling methods can explain multiple perspectives and foster empathy, but must avoid oversimplifying lived realities. In line with this argument, Carbajal and Caswell (2021) point out that digital archival practices involve similar ethical challenges, as digitization and online dissemination may inadvertently perpetuate existing power dynamics, colonial legacies, and be reused in a disrespectful manner. Digitizing archival material can also amplify archival silences and replicate exploitative relationships through unauthorized reuse, commodification, or the loss of original context (Carbajal & Caswell, 2021). The authors, therefore, emphasize that digital records are not unbiased but embody the political and social decisions of archivists, underscoring the importance of critical reflection on how archives are created, presented, and used (Carbajal & Caswell, 2021). Carbajal and Caswell (2021) also address the disconnect between archivists and online users. Because digital archives often remove face-to-face interaction, archivists may feel distant from the people using their materials. This makes it harder to understand or measure how their work is actually used by and affecting people. To address these concerns, Carbajal and Caswell (2021) highlight the importance of attentiveness to the emotional, educational, and social justice impacts of digital archival practices, especially those that represent marginalized voices, to counteract harmful effects such as

"...symbolic annihilation"—that is, the absence, underrepresentation, or misrepresentation of marginalized groups in media and archives." (p. 1112). Thus, Carbajal and Caswell's (2021) insights reinforce and expand upon Rouse's (2019) call for critical reflection and reflexive approaches that actively address power imbalances and ensure ethical engagement when reimagining historical narratives in digital spaces.

These concerns are further elaborated in Todd Presner's (2016) discussion surrounding the digital representation of Holocaust culture, where he critically analyzes the ethical tensions that emerge at the intersection of memory culture, data, and algorithmic mediation. A key concern Presner (2016) highlights involves how large-scale digital projects, such as vast archives and platforms, attempt to honor individual stories while operating at a scale that risks flattening or aestheticizing personal suffering. Projects like the *Digital Monument to the Jewish Community* in the Netherlands or the *Shoah Foundation Visual History Archive* reveal how digitization can enable broader access but can inadvertently diminish emotional nuance and obscure the human depth behind the data. Additionally, Presner (2016) points out how algorithms that organize, index, and present such material play an active role in shaping historical interpretation, which often embeds certain biases or limiting narrative possibilities. Though often perceived as neutral, these algorithmic systems reflect subjective decisions about metadata structures, categorization, and user pathways, which can unintentionally prioritize certain aspects of history over others. This raises critical ethical questions about how digital systems might distance users from the trauma and uncertainty inherent in personal Holocaust testimonies, fostering passive or superficial engagement (Presner, 2016). As with other forms of digital cultural heritage, Presner (2016) advocates that these sensitive digital representations must balance technological possibility with ethical responsibility to avoid dehumanization and foreground sensitivity and complexity in the risk of simplification.

Drawing on this, Rouse (2019; see also Palombini, 2017) further argues that designers and researchers should view digital cultural heritage not as a quest for a definitive truth but as an ongoing dialogue. This point is relevant for contested or stigmatized histories, such as those encountered in prison archives, where the archival record was shaped by institutions with interests that may not align with the perspectives of those incarcerated (Bruce-Lockhart & Akande, 2024; Spillane, 2024). Being critically aware of and employing the ethical responsibilities of the designer or researcher in telling someone else's narrative in a digital space can help digital heritage projects not to unintentionally reinforce historical power imbalances or continue harmful narratives (Rouse, 2019). Palombini (2017) also highlights the need to carefully balance historical accuracy and narrative creativity when applying digital storytelling techniques to cultural heritage, arguing "Not to tell anything conflicting with historical documentation, as far as we know it" (p. 138). Thus, while digital storytelling can powerfully engage audiences, it simultaneously carries the ethical responsibility of transparently handling historical ambiguities and clearly distinguishing between documented evidence and interpretative narrative choices.

4 Theoretical basis

The digital turn in humanities research has transformed the ways in which historical materials are archived, accessed, presented, and interpreted (Drucker, 2021). While digitization is often framed as a neutral or objective process that enhances accessibility and preservation, scholars within Critical Digital Humanities (CDH) challenge this assumption, emphasizing how digital technologies embed ideological, ethical, and interpretive biases (Drucker, 2021; Dobson, 2019; Berry, 2022; Viola, 2023). To address this, CDH highlights the need for more direct critical methodologies that facilitate exploratory and interpretive engagement with digital cultural heritage (Viola, 2023; Benardou & Droumpouki, 2022). For this reason, this study critically examines the ethical challenges of animating prison archives by analyzing how digital heritage projects digitally mediate historical incarcerated individuals and their histories. By employing a critical digital humanities framework, this research explores the processes by which these digital archives construct meaning, shape narratives, and potentially reinforce or challenge existing power structures.

Following this discussion, it is important to note that while Critical Heritage Studies (CHS) and CDH share overlapping concerns around issues of memory, identity, power, and representation, I have chosen to frame this thesis through a CDH theoretical lens. CHS offers critical insights into how heritage is constructed, contested, and negotiated across different cultural, historical, and social contexts, and it has contributed meaningfully to rethinking heritage as a continuous negotiation of past and present (Viola, 2023). However, the specific aims of this thesis call for a framework that not only analyzes how the past is remembered through digital means but also how digital technologies and spaces shape the conditions of remembering. Therefore, applying CDH provides the theoretical tools necessary to interrogate how the digital platforms mediate sensitive historical narratives and how digital tools not only structure access to historical material but also influence its interpretative dimensions. This approach allowed me to critically explore the interpretive experience of engaging with digital incarceration archives, as well as my positionality within these interactions. Thus, applying CDH as a theoretical foundation emphasizes the importance of critical reflection on the role of technology, human biases, and their implications for knowledge production, power structures, and social justice

4.1 Critical Digital Humanities

The humanities are inherently interpretive, engaging in critical reflection on the present in relation to tradition and human experience (Dalbello, 2011). This reflection includes both the processes of meaning-making and knowledge production, as well as the tools that facilitate these processes. Within this context, digital technology has become a broader focus of the humanities, functioning as both a methodological instrument and an object of study (Dalbello, 2011). The field of digital humanities specifically examines how digital tools transform writing, thinking, and teaching within humanistic disciplines, shaping both scholarly

practices and the ways knowledge is constructed and disseminated (Dalbello, 2011; Drucker, 2021). Today, digital humanities employ a diverse range of scholarly initiatives, including interactive digital collections and large-scale digital editing projects. Many of these digital resources have become foundational within their respective disciplines, shaping both research methodologies and epistemological frameworks. Beyond their functional role, these resources have served as sites of theoretical inquiry, explored through narrative theory, aesthetics, and the politics of digital networks (Dalbello, 2011). Engaging with digital heritage projects not only broadens possible research questions but also influences the ways scholars conceptualize and reason through their work, which can foster new critical and interpretive possibilities within the humanities.

In response to this need for critical framing, I have constructed a curated critical assemblage of theoretical concepts from CDH to guide the analysis of how digital incarceration archives embed values, assumptions, and biases, and how they ethically mediate sensitive historical incarceration data and narratives. Specifically, I use post-authenticity to examine how the digital platforms may or may not blur distinctions between original and reconstructed historical narratives, challenging assumptions of neutrality in digital representations. Additionally, I engage with critical reflexivity, curatorial decisions, deformation, and reflexive research practices that foreground the researcher's positionality and the ethical implications of digital mediation to serve as analytical tools to examine how the digital platforms ethically frame sensitive historical knowledge. The following subsections present the theoretical components in detail, outlining how each informs the interpretive and critical lenses applied throughout the analysis.

4.1.1 Curatorial meaning-making

Digital humanists have long engaged with Alan Liu's influential call to approach digital humanities with a more critical and reflective lens (Boyles, 2018). Christina Boyles (2018) builds on this by emphasizing that within digital humanities, it is not sufficient to assess only technical skills, but students and scholars must also question and reshape the digital landscapes they interact with. In particular, Boyles (2018) highlights how digital archives are sites where power is exercised through decisions of curation, access, and representation. Boyles (2018) offers a method for interrogating the "archives of humanity" grounded in cultural critique and social justice by "[l]inking curation to making and breaking, two digital humanities approaches to meaning-making" (para 1). Making refers to the construction of new forms of knowledge, while breaking involves critically analyzing harmful or biased representations. While Boyles focuses specifically on the classroom and student learning in ethical and critical practices, I adopt this thinking in my thesis to critically engage with curatorial decisions, digital representations, and the interpretive frameworks that structure the later analyzed digital heritage platforms.

4.1.2 Post-authentic framework

Lorella Viola's (2023) open-access volume *The Humanities in the Digital: Beyond Critical Digital Humanities* acts as a foundational reference for applying this theoretical approach. Viola's (2023) publication calls for a fundamental shift in how

knowledge is produced and disseminated in the digital era. It challenges conventional boundaries in digital scholarship and proposes a new conceptual model called the post-authentic framework, which argues for moving beyond rigid distinctions, such as digital versus non-digital, and critiques the positivist assumptions embedded in digital tools and methodologies (Viola, 2023). This means that rather than viewing digitization as a neutral process of preservation and access, it interrogates the ideological and technological frameworks that shape digital archives, emphasizing how these processes reflect, reinforce, or disrupt existing power structures (Viola, 2023; Berry, 2022). In other words, the post-authentic approach has also guided me in examining the reconstructed narratives not as fixed representations or authentic historical copies, but as dynamic portrayals embedded in complex networks of choices, actors, and interpretations.

4.1.3 Critical reflexivity: challenging digital selectivity

Another scholar who advocates for critical engagement within the digital space is David M. Berry (2014; 2022). For Berry (2014; 2022), critical practice and reflexivity enable digital humanists to examine the intersection of critical theory and the digital critically. Berry (2022) emphasizes how digital technologies impose a selective framework, influencing how knowledge transforms into data, and how these shifts have tangible implications on how knowledge is stored, represented, and communicated. As Berry (2022) highlights, “Critical digital humanities draws attention to the politics and norms that are embedded in digital technology, algorithms, and software.” (p. 130). Consequently, he argues that critical digital humanities should actively identify and challenge these imposed selectivities and distortions by continuously critiquing the digital infrastructures themselves (Berry, 2022). Moreover, Berry (2022) states how CDH “...should not only map these challenges but also propose new ways of reconfiguring research, teaching, and knowledge representation to safeguard critical and rational thought in a digital age” (p. 130). Therefore, Berry’s (2022) critical approach underscores a necessity for digital humanists to remain attentive against computational methodologies that risk obscuring the distinction between concepts and objects or weakening the critical faculties essential to humanistic inquiry. He calls for developing a critical reflexive humanism where computational approaches are reframed not as forces of dominance or control but as reflexive and democratic tools designed to support critical thinking and ethical reasoning. Essentially, Berry (2022) advocates for recognizing digital tools as fundamentally human-crafted structures that should prioritize humanistic values and serve collective well-being rather than being seen as separate or adversarial to humanistic thought.

This critical perspective was considered essential for analyzing the two digital platforms, which engage with sensitive materials in contexts “...where meanings and values are challenged” (Rouhani, 2023, p. 2) and in which prison records were designed for administrative purposes and not to document human experiences (Johnston et al., 2013). This is in line with Bijan Rouhani's (2023) discussion on the evolving understanding of cultural heritage as no longer just a collection of objects and places from the past but rather a social and cultural process that includes the creation and interpretation of its meaning and values. While digital collections may

appear to offer objective or transparent access to historical materials, they are, in fact, highly mediated constructs (Viola, 2023). Choices related to navigation structures, metadata, and visual design influence how users interpret and engage with digitized records (Viola, 2023).

4.1.4 Deformance and interpretation

The use of contemporary digital tools to reorient historical data can be understood through the lens of "...what Stephen Ramsay, following Jerome McGann and Lisa Samuels, calls "deformation" (Dobson, 2019, p. 82). James E. Dobson (2019) states that when we use digital tools to change or distort how historical data is shown, it can actually help us see the past in a new way. This process means deliberately reshaping something to reveal different meanings. Instead of trying to present digital history as fixed or neutral, this approach invites us to question how we understand the past and who gets to shape that understanding. From a CDH perspective, this concept helps uncover hidden power structures and reminds us that all digital representations are shaped by choices. In other words, by deforming data, intentionally bending or shifting it, it is not necessarily falsifying history, but instead, if ethically applied, enabling reflective, and often more inclusive engagements with it in the present (Dobson, 2019). This theoretical concept was applied in this study to explore how digital methods can interrupt normative readings and instead foreground the interpretive frameworks and assumptions embedded in scholarly practices themselves.

4.1.5 Disclosive and goodwill ethics

One of the key ethical challenges in digital humanities comes from its interdisciplinary foundation, as fields like the humanities and computer science have historically developed distinct approaches to ethical training and reasoning, often leading to differing perspectives on how to navigate ethical considerations in research (Proferes, 2020). Proferes (2020) articulates how digital humanists should engage with what he describes what Brey (2000, 2010) discuss as *disclosive ethics*. This methodological approach seeks to uncover morally ambiguous aspects of digital technologies and methods, making the values embedded within them visible (Proferes, 2020). Given the digital humanities' engagement with emerging technologies, where ethical implications may not always be apparent, disclosive ethics offers a more structured framework for critical reflection by identifying and describing ethical issues before attempting to address them. This approach can "...help identify morally opaque practices, and once properly identified, help the researcher reflect on these features from a moral perspective" (Proferes, 2020, p. 424), where ethical considerations are either overlooked or unrecognized.

Kelley (2020) offers a complementary approach through what she terms *goodwill ethics*, emphasizing the relational aspects of ethics within digital research methods. Kelley (2020) highlights the importance of ongoing ethical engagement with research participants, particularly in online communities, and argues that traditional ethical clearance processes, such as those derived from the *Belmont Report*, often fail to fully capture the complexities of research conducted in digital environments.

Instead, Kelley (2020) advocates for a more situational and participatory ethical model, one that prioritizes respect, reciprocity, transparency, and vulnerability in researcher-participant relationships. This approach is relevant when working with human subjects in digital spaces, where issues of consent, privacy, and representation require continuous negotiation rather than a one-time ethical approval (Kelley, 2020). By recognizing the potential power imbalance between researchers and participants, she encourages scholars to engage in self-reflection and actively consider how their research might impact those whose voices and experiences they document.

Following these approaches was especially relevant for my study, as the interviews with scholars involved in the projects served to deepen the insights from my digital autoethnographic analysis. Embracing Kelley's (2020) goodwill ethics furthers our understanding of the ethical complexities within interdisciplinary research, particularly in relation to how scholars navigate ethical concerns in their own work. This allowed me to approach these interviews not just as data collection but as an opportunity for ethical engagement. While Proferes' (2020) discussion on disclosive ethics primarily addresses ethical dilemmas in data use and infrastructures, its emphasis on making ethical considerations more distinct also informs this study. Instead of treating research ethics as a procedural requirement, this study incorporates Proferes' (2020) call for ethics as contemplation, a more context-sensitive approach to ethics, using interviews to explore how scholars reason through ethical dilemmas in their work with digital prison archives.

5 Methodology

For the purpose of this study, a qualitative research approach was applied to explore and interpret narrative strategies and analyze interactions within the digital incarceration platforms rather than focusing on statistical patterns and understandings. As Bhattacharya (2008) states, the goal of empirical research is "...to observe phenomena in the social world so as to generate knowledge about these phenomena" (p. 254). To achieve this, I conducted a digital autoethnographic study to analyze ethical challenges and how the representations of incarcerated individuals' narratives and materials showcased by two digital platforms shaped my experience and understanding. However, while a qualitative methodology's strengths are its depth and targeted approach, this thesis's empirical research has limitations. For example, the ambiguity of claiming that all knowledge comes from experience can imply that empirical research, limited by its definitions and interpretations, may lead to a narrow or incomplete understanding of complex phenomena (Bhattacharya, 2008). This highlights the importance of recognizing that this study and the ethical reflections discussed are not objective or absolute truths but rather critical interpretations shaped by the specific perspectives and methodological choices employed.

5.1 Purpose and aims

This thesis examines how digital heritage projects animate historical incarceration narratives through digital platforms. Focusing on the reconstruction of digitized archival materials, textual narratives, audio-recorded biographies, and AI-generated visualizations, it critically explores how these representations are experienced through an embodied perspective. By reflecting on my own engagement with these digital historical narratives, alongside insights from scholars involved in digital incarceration heritage projects, this research investigates how such encounters can inform alternative ways of studying and understanding ethical approaches for mediating and representing difficult histories within digital platforms.

The research questions this study seeks to answer are:

1. What ethical reflections and challenges emerge in the digital reimagining of historical incarceration narratives when analyzed through an embodied and reflexive approach?

2. What alternative ethical strategies could be considered when animating historical narratives of incarceration?

    2.1 How can interpretive pauses support reflective engagement with digital representations of sensitive historical narratives?

    2.2 How can digital platforms avoid sensationalistic portrayals of personal incarceration histories?

2.3 How does researcher's reflexivity and methodological transparency contribute to more ethical digital representations of personal incarceration narratives?

To address these questions, this study integrates a digital autoethnographic analysis, complemented by two conducted interviews, to offer an alternative way, focusing on emotional and self-reflexive empirical findings, in examining how digital heritage platforms utilize various narrative approaches to engage audiences with difficult cultural heritage. Drawing on the empirical findings, the study discusses various alternative ethical strategies and considerations for animating historical incarceration narratives. Through this qualitative approach, this thesis seeks to contribute to broader discussions on digital ethics, heritage representation, and the transformative potential of digital tools in reinterpreting complex historical narratives.

5.2 Method

5.2.1 Digital autoethnography

Autoethnography is a research method that integrates personal reflection with cultural analysis that positions the researcher within the study rather than as an external observer (Gobo & Molle, 2016; Goode et al., 2023). Emerging from postmodern ethnography, it challenges the assumption that researchers can objectively analyze *the other* and instead emphasizes reflexivity, encouraging scholars to critically examine their own biases, ideology, and research practices (Gobo & Molle, 2016). In this way, autoethnography differs from traditional ethnographic methods by placing the researcher's own experiences at the center of the analysis. In other words, while many qualitative methods strive for researcher neutrality, autoethnography embraces self-reflection as integral to the research process and acknowledges the researcher's presence and how their experiences shape interpretations. However, critics argue that with excessive self-focus, where a "...researcher focuses on his or her own actions and thoughts, with no practical or methodological payoff, he or she may wind up in a self-reflexive dead end" (Gobo & Molle, 2016, p. 67). While it is often seen as subjective, its goal is not objectivity but rather a deeper connection between personal narratives and broader cultural or social contexts (Gobo & Molle, 2016; Goode et al., 2023). More specifically, autoethnographic studies are typically written in the first person and incorporate emotions, introspection, journaling, and dialogue to explore relational dynamics shaped by history, social structures, and cultural contexts (Gobo & Molle, 2016). While making the researcher a central figure, the analytical approach still connects self-reflection with critical engagement (Anderson, 2006).

Stemming from this, Calzati (2020; see also Dunn & Myers, 2020) discusses digital autoethnography as a method that applies the personal narrative described above with critical engagement in digital environments. This approach builds on traditional autoethnography but extends it into the digital space, where researchers examine their own interactions, identities, and experiences within online spaces (Calzati, 2020; Dunn & Myers, 2020). Digital autoethnography provides a reflexive analysis

through which scholars can analyze how digital platforms and media shape personal and collective meaning-making, as well as how online interactions influence self-representation and cultural practices. Dunn and Myers (2020) emphasize that digital autoethnography is essential for maintaining methodological relevance in an increasingly digitalized world, arguing that researchers must critically engage with their own digital presence to understand broader cultural and technological shifts. Similarly, Kozinets (2019), in his work on netnography, suggests that self-reflective engagement with digital communities is a crucial aspect of contemporary ethnographic research, as online spaces become dominant sites of social interaction. Calzati (2020) demonstrates this through a practice-based teaching project, where students analyzed their social media behaviors to develop critical digital literacy. This method aligns with critical digital humanities perspectives in how scholars should explore not just digital content but how online interactions shape the experience and understanding of power structures, biases, and ethical considerations embedded in digital spaces and technologies.

While digital autoethnography has primarily been applied to studies of social media experiences, its potential extends to the exploration of other digital platforms and interactions. As Staidum (2022) discusses, autoethnographic approaches in digital humanities offer to critically engage with the affective, embodied, and subjective dimensions of interacting with digital representations of contested histories. His research approach in combining digital autoethnography and deep mapping of the spatial and economic entanglements of slavery in antebellum New Orleans demonstrates how autoethnography can serve as a methodological strategy to acknowledge the emotional and ethical complexities of studying difficult heritage (Staidum, 2022). This concept highlights how the researcher's bodily and emotional responses to digital tools and digitized archival materials can inform new methodological insights, challenging the presumed objectivity of computational analysis. Therefore, by embedding personal reflection within digital research, digital autoethnography allows scholars to interrogate how digital infrastructures mediate historical narratives, shape user experience, and reproduce or resist power structures (Staidum, 2022). These digital environments are not only repositories of historical and cultural narratives but also active spaces where meaning is shaped through technological means, design, and the ways users interact with the materials presented. By positioning myself as a participant in this study, I shift the focus from interpreting other participants' emotional responses to documenting my observations, emotions, and experiences when engaging with the digital incarceration archives.

This methodological approach enables a more self-reflexive analysis and embodied engagement with the platforms, moving beyond detached observation and towards a situated analysis of how these collections mediate the understanding of historically incarcerated individuals. As a result, unlike structured interviews or surveys, which provide data at fixed points in time, digital autoethnography allows for an ongoing engagement with the evolving online narratives and interactions.

To add further discursive reflections to the autoethnographic analysis, I conducted semi-structured online interviews with scholars involved in the development of these digital archives (see section 5.2.2). This approach ensured that external perspectives on the process of implementing ethical considerations were incorporated into the study, mitigating the potential limitations of relying solely on my subjective engagement. The challenge of this work lies in applying these methodological techniques to observing my own actions, conducting self-reflection as an interview process, documenting my personal experiences, and analyzing my cultural contributions. To make this possible, Gibbs (2018) highlights that reflexivity is essential in qualitative research as it recognizes that no researcher can claim absolute objectivity. Following this perspective, I actively engage in critical reflexivity by examining how my own positionality and background influence my interpretations. My experience as a digital humanities student brings specific expectations to my engagement with these archives, and part of the analysis involves documenting how these preconceptions shape my understanding. Reflexivity is not about eliminating the researcher's influence but about acknowledging, monitoring, and transparently reporting its effects (Gibbs, 2018). In line with this, I critically assessed my methodological approach, considering the limitations and potential biases that arise from self-observation while also ensuring that my findings are open to external examination by implementing quotes from my journaling. Consequently, by blending my personal experience with a critical analysis of the two digital environments, digital autoethnography provided an interpretive depth that other qualitative methods may lack when studying online interactions with sensitive historical materials.

I structured my autoethnographic analysis based on key points from *The Qualitative Report* by Cooper and Lilyea (2022), instructors in the Qualitative Research Graduate Certificate Program at Nova Southeastern University, to ensure alignment with their recommendations on how to “do autoethnography”. Below, I present the framework of how each step in the analysis connects to Cooper and Lilyea's (2022) qualitative report and how they were implemented in this study:

Phase	Description	How enacted & timeframe
Developing the research questions	Identify the research questions that connect my personal experiences to cultural issues that guide the exploration and framework for my narrative.	The research questions were developed iteratively between February and June 2025, shaped by ongoing journal and interview reflections, and emerging themes from my engagement with the platforms.
Collecting data	Gather data from my personal experiences with descriptive self-observations from journal entries.	I engaged with each platform between 5 –10 March 2025, journaling with 4 sessions (approx. 4 hours per session). Produced 8 journal entries in total. Following the initial journaling, two online interviews were conducted, as discursive enrichments to the autoethnographic entries, on 13 and 24 March 2025.
Crafting the narrative	Combining descriptive-realistic, analytical-interpretive, and confessional-emotive writing styles to ensure that the exploration is both evocative and analytical.	Ongoing throughout the journaling period, during which I began shaping the tone and structure of my narrative through personal reflection, analytical and emotionally grounded description. In April 2025, I selected and transcribed key journal entries and relevant excerpts from the interview conversations that aligned with the focus of the study. These materials formed the basis for the content presented in the analysis section.
Analyzing and interpreting the data	Analyze and interpret the findings by identifying themes and patterns that connect my personal experiences to the broader cultural context.	Thematic analysis conducted in May 2025, drawing from journal entries, interview excerpts, and CDH theoretical readings. Identified key themes presented in the results and discussion sections.
Engaging in reflexivity	Reflect on my positionality and ethical responsibilities throughout the process to minimize the risk to others by protecting them from harm.	Ongoing throughout the study, with explicit documentation of my positionality, where I reflect on how my interpretations are shaped by subjective and context-specific experiences. Information about individuals who did not consent to having their names or experiences included was excluded.

Figure 1. Table created by the author, June 10, 2025.

Following this framework, it is important to critically reflect on my position as a master's student in digital humanities and how my background has influenced my engagement with the analyzed digital heritage platforms. Before beginning my involvement with digital humanities, I studied and maintained a longstanding

interest in how difficult or contested heritage sites are preserved, experienced, and understood today from a more traditional humanities perspective. Previously, my studies primarily focused on physical sites of contested heritage, critically examining how personal narratives connected to these places were preserved, represented, or sometimes neglected within contemporary cultural and historical practices. Entering the field of digital humanities has allowed me to deepen my understanding of how historical research and sensitive narratives can be mediated and reimagined in digital spaces through digital tools and methodologies. This shift in focus from physical to digital contexts has significantly expanded my perspective with new insights into the potentials and complexities associated with digitally preserving and interpreting sensitive historical narratives.

Regardless of whether the discussion is grounded in traditional humanities or digital humanities, ethical considerations consistently present complexities and are rarely straightforward to apply. Existing ethical principles and frameworks are crucial in guiding respectful and responsible research practices (see section 2.3). However, it is important to note that I am not an expert in ethical questions, rather, I have struggled to navigate and fully grasp the complexity of ethically researching and digitally presenting personal stories derived from historical records of individuals who have long been deceased, particularly when their pasts are from a vulnerable place. My intention with this thesis is, therefore, to critically explore whether there are alternative ethical reflections, studied from an embodied perspective, that could be considered within the evolving interdisciplinary field of digital humanities to address its unique and nuanced ethical challenges. Thus, I specifically chose digital autoethnography to allow myself to observe and reflect from my own perspective, thereby gaining insights into how ethical considerations influence these digital presentations and exploring ways in which my analysis, informed by my viewpoint, can contribute meaningfully to the broader ethical discourse within digital humanities.

5.2.2 Online interviews

To complement my subjective and embodied engagement with the platforms, I conducted two online semi-structured interviews with project scholars, who were selected based on their direct involvement in the analyzed digital heritage projects, to address the limitations of my own positionality within the digital autoethnographic process. While journaling surfaced interpretive and emotional reflections, it also risked overlooking deeper structural and ethical dimensions embedded in the digital reconstruction of incarceration narratives. The interviews provided a dialogical counterpoint, helping to surface perspectives that were not immediately visible through my personal engagement alone.

Following this, online interviews are a form of primary data gathering and must be performed following ethical research guidelines (Kozinets, 2019). As Kozinets (2019) points out, the interviews should be conducted rigorously to ensure alignment with the research focus and questions. More specifically, the objectives of each interview should be carefully matched to the interviewee and the chosen online platform. Consequently, I have maintained the same method, using the online

platform Zoom, with both interviews to enhance comparability and reliability. Also, both interviews had a duration of around thirty minutes and were both recorded and transcribed by the author. The interview questions that guided the conversations are provided in the appendix (see appendix A and B). While the recordings and full transcriptions are not publicly available and are therefore not included in this thesis, I was granted permission to share direct quotes from our conversations, specifically selected to illustrate key points relevant to my analysis. Furthermore, preparing open-ended, non-leading questions was crucial to allow the interviewees to share freely. But perhaps the most important step to ensure an ethically grounded online interview was to maintain transparency before beginning the conversation, where I clearly explained the purpose of the interview, provided all interview questions in advance, and obtained informed consent to use the interviewees' titles, names and quotations from our conversation (Kozinets, 2019).

The first interview was conducted on March 13, 2025, with Andrew Redfern, the project coordinator for the *Ironclad Sisterhood* project. Redfern is an educator, technology consultant, artificial intelligence specialist, and family historian. His involvement in developing the *Ironclad Sisterhood* project's website, database, and images created with artificial intelligence based on historical records contributed to our discussion on how the project team faced ethical challenges in their creative approach to share a sensitive history. The following and last interview was carried out on March 24, 2025, with Professor Barry Godfrey, the principal investigator for the *Digital Panopticon* project. Godfrey is a criminologist, educator, researcher, and specialist in comparative criminology, international crime history, and longitudinal studies of offending. His academic background and work experiences in developing the *Digital Panopticon* gave further insights into the complexities of adhering to ethical guidelines when working with historical criminal records, privacy issues, and terminology.

By incorporating these qualitative in-depth interviews, the digital autoethnographic analysis was enriched in several important ways. Firstly, it discursively elaborated the findings from the autoethnographic entries by offering alternative perspectives, clarifying platform intentions, and foregrounding ethical considerations that may have remained obscured through personal engagement alone. Secondly, these conversations enabled a deeper exploration of the ethical considerations, methodologies, and challenges involved in digitally representing complex historical materials from a practitioner’s point of view. Lastly, including these scholarly perspectives in my analysis allowed this research to go beyond personal reflections, adding layers of complexity and critical depth to the findings derived from my digital autoethnographic approach. This also contributed to a broader discussion surrounding the ethical reimagining and respectful mediation of sensitive personal narratives within digital heritage scholarship.

5.2.3 Conducting the analysis

Building on the findings from the digital autoethnographic analysis and online interviews, the analysis will end with a thematic results discussion. This is to address which ethical challenges the two analyzed digital incarceration platforms

faced and how my own experiences align with or differ from the perspectives of the interviewed practitioners. By analyzing the intersections between researcher experience and professional insights, the study discusses alternative ethical strategies that could help guide future digital heritage projects dealing with the narratives and representation of historically incarcerated individuals. This approach allowed me to critically evaluate the ethical strategies employed in the *Digital Panopticon* and *Ironclad Sisterhood*, identifying both exemplary practices and areas where ethical engagement could be enhanced. Also, to again emphasize that rather than aiming for definitive conclusions, it is important to highlight that this approach is heuristic, therefore, the focus lies on identifying patterns and interpretive strategies within the selected digital platforms (Knight 2001). By comparing the findings from my interactions with these platforms and the interviewees' reflections on ethical dilemmas and decision-making, I evaluated how the projects navigated the challenges of representation, interpretation, and deeper engagement with the narratives of historically incarcerated individuals.

As described in previous sections, this study examines two similar yet contrasting digital incarceration archives: the *Digital Panopticon* and *Ironclad Sisterhood*. These platforms were chosen due to their distinct methodological approaches to representing historical incarceration. They provide a comparative foundation to explore how digital heritage projects construct and mediate historical memory, agency, and ethical engagement differently. However, the intent of this study is not to assess all aspects of the selected platforms but rather to investigate the specific ways in which two individuals' stories are mediated through digital representation. Therefore, given the limited scope of this master's thesis (30 credits) and the time constraints associated with it, this study does not aim for a comprehensive analysis of all aspects of these platforms. Instead, I have narrowed the focus to two individual narratives within each platform, examining how their representation is shaped through textual, visual, and interactive elements. By limiting the scope in this way, I could provide a focused and in-depth analysis of specific mediations of incarceration narratives rather than a broad but superficial overview of the platforms in their entirety.

By examining how historical figures are portrayed in this way, through a CDH theoretical lens, this study analyzes whether individuals are framed as passive subjects within the institutional records or if they have agency and voice within the archive, and assesses how narrative positioning influences historical interpretation. Drawing on concepts such as reflexive research practices, post-authenticity, curatorial decisions, and deformation, the study explores how digital platforms may blur the line between original and reconstructed narratives, challenging assumptions of neutrality in digital representations. The comparison helps evaluate the ethical implications of different framing strategies, particularly in terms of how digital heritage platforms do or do not balance factual accuracy with affective storytelling. The visual elements will also be critically explored, focusing on the types of images and interactive choices that contribute to user perception. Finally, the analysis assesses whether the digital platforms promote passive consumption of pre-curated narratives or actively encourage critical interpretation. This is done by evaluating

the extent to which I, as the user, am given the tools to critically engage with or challenge the presented narratives.

5.3 Ethical considerations and limitations

To ensure an ethically grounded study, I firstly acknowledge the inherent subjectivity of my position as a master's student in digital humanities and how my perspective is influenced by my academic background, and my research aims to explore alternative ethical challenges in digital representations of personal incarceration narratives. My engagement with the *Digital Panopticon* and *Ironclad Sisterhood* is guided by an active search for ethical practices, which inevitably shapes my observations and interpretations. Secondly, while this analysis is concerned with moral questions in digitally reimagining historical narratives, it does not engage deeply with the technical infrastructure of digital platforms, such as metadata standards or long-term data preservation strategies. Instead, the focus remains on how personal narratives and sensitive historical materials are represented outside of these practices. Therefore, rather than creating a structured ethical framework for managing complex data, I critically explore how incarceration histories are presented, interpreted, and engaged with in connection to context, emotion, and subjectivity in ethical digital curation. Thirdly, I recognize that my experiences may not fully reflect those of others, such as scholars with higher expertise or members of the public with no prior academic training. Recognizing these biases is essential, as it allows me to reflect critically on how my position influences my understanding of the platforms and the ethical challenges they may present.

Lastly, to adhere to the ethical guidelines emphasized by Sparkes (2024; see also Cooper & Lilyea, 2022) when conducting an autoethnographic analysis, this study engages deeply with the principle of *do no harm* to both self and others. This involves an intentional decision to exclude the names, identities, and personal experiences of individuals in my immediate environment to protect their anonymity and confidentiality. Sparkes (2024) emphasizes the complex and often messy nature of ethical responsibilities of ensuring absolute anonymity and confidentiality in personal and sensitive narratives. Acknowledging this complexity, my ethical approach prioritizes minimizing potential harm by consciously limiting the discussion to my own experiences and narrative rather than involving personal accounts from my private relationships.

Having discussed the essential ethical considerations, theoretical frameworks, and methodological approaches guiding this research in previous sections, the following chapter illustrates how these approaches are applied practically in this thesis analysis of digital representations of historical incarceration narratives and presents the following results.

6 Analysis and results

This chapter presents the empirical findings of this study through the lens of CDH in analyzing how digital heritage platforms represent incarceration narratives through creative, ethical, and technical mediation. Using a digital autoethnographic lens, complemented by online interviews with scholars involved in the projects, I explore how the *Digital Panopticon* and *Ironclad Sisterhood* reconstruct historical lives, and how my own interpretive experience helps reveal ethical tensions, narrative strategies, and power structures embedded in the digital representations.

The chapter begins with a brief reflection on embodied knowledge in digital research and my positionality (see section 6.1). The following sections (see 6.2 and 6.3) offer an in-depth digital autoethnographic analysis of the *Digital Panopticon* and *Ironclad Sisterhood* platforms. These two longer sections include journal entries and interview material to allow the reader to follow my personal engagement and interpretive process in detail, rather than relying solely on my analytical divisions. The final section (see 6.4) and its subsections then present the main results through a thematic analysis, highlighting the alternative ethical strategies and reflections identified.

6.1 Reflections on my positionality and embodied knowledge

Building on the methodological discussion of digital autoethnography (see section 5.2.1), Staidum (2022) further emphasizes the importance of embodied knowledge in digital research, stating:

> "...we must do more than depict, digitize, and compute. We must be attuned to the affects of the computing body and the consciousnesses they engender. By attuning oneself to the impulses, sensations, and affects of manipulating the computer hardware, software, and digitized data, the researcher accesses a type of embodied knowledge, which is not necessarily the end product but a method of asking different questions, sensing forgotten positionalities, and speculating the unthinkable." (Staidum, 2022, p. 62)

This idea, articulated by Staidum (2022), underscores the significance of incorporating alternative methodologies within digital humanities to explore further affective and ethical concerns that could also guide the creation of digital representations and mediations of historical incarceration narratives. Additionally, it resonated with me as I engaged with the digitally reconstructed narratives presented by the *Digital Panopticon* and *Ironclad Sisterhood*. Even though these are not immersive platforms, the two projects still impacted how I connected with the sensitive past they aim to share. Instead of just focusing on the outcomes (like a completed visualization or database), Stadium (2022) argues that the act of engaging with digital tools, data, and archives, and the experience of navigating, interpreting, and interacting with them itself is valuable to analyze when working within historical research and digitization. The structure and framing of the reimagined narratives and the choice of imagery shaped my understanding and experience, not

just of the individuals represented but of the mechanisms of historical remembrance itself. These platforms do not simply present history, but they mediate it, influencing the questions I asked myself, the emotions I felt, and the positionalities I became aware of in ways I had not anticipated during this process.

As I conducted this analysis, I carried with me both gratitude and caution. I was grateful for the work that brought these stories to light. But I was also deeply aware that the representations were not neutral, and neither were the ways I engaged with them. Every choice in representation, such as a title, a photograph, or a categorization, framed what I could and could not see. And so, my task has not been just to observe but to interrogate. Not just to engage but to reflect.

In the following sections, I further discuss the empirical findings and results of this research. Additionally, I include screenshots (Figures 2-11) taken from my desktop of my journey visiting and exploring the digital platforms. The pictures serve as a visual record of my interactions with the digital platforms, as well as to capture the interface and the various materials I encountered during my digital autoethnographic exploration.

6.2 Reconstructed incarceration narratives in the Digital Panopticon

In this section, I critically examine the digital reconstructions of Sarah Durrant (1808) and Mary Ann Hall (1840) incarceration narratives presented by the *Digital Panopticon* from my own position as a master's student in digital humanities. My analysis is grounded in digital autoethnography as a means of exploring how my personal responses can help reveal alternative and underlying ethical considerations in how this digital heritage platform mediates and reconstructs the lives and experiences of historically incarcerated individuals. In doing so, I also draw on key ethical concerns raised by Barry Godfrey during our meeting to further reflect on the project's ethical tensions and choices. In my interview with Godfrey, he referenced his previous work and embraced that I could further reflect on our conversations from the articles he has written on the topic. Therefore, I will also draw on key research articles previously written by Godfrey in connection with our conversation.

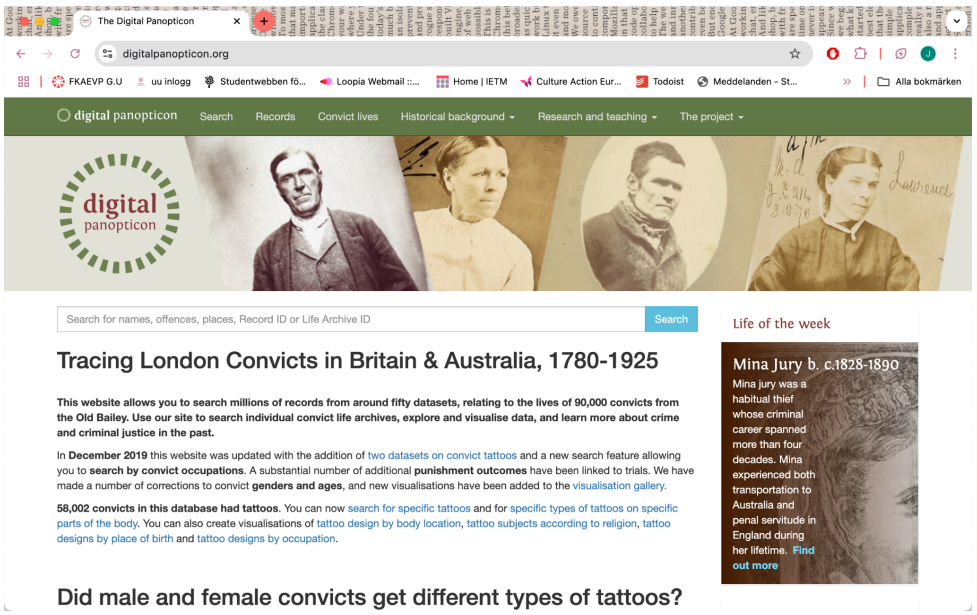


Figure 2. The Digital Panopticon (2025). *Main page*. Screenshot by author. https://www.digitalpanopticon.org/

As previously stated (see section 2.1), the *Digital Panopticon* gives access to records of 90,000 incarcerated individuals sentenced at the Old Bailey between 1780 and 1925 (*The Digital Panopticon*, n.d.). This huge database and platform of fifty combined datasets also manages to share reconstructed individual life stories. When I opened the project's homepage (see Figure 2), my eyes quickly landed on four unfamiliar faces stretched across the banner. I wrote in my journal:

> "Some stare directly at me. Others look off to the side, like the camera caught them just before they turned away. But I see no names here, so I pause. I am expecting names, some sign of recognition maybe. But instead of not showing the actual faces and people that this history is about, I think it makes me more pleased to be able to see them than not to. But I am still feeling like these people that once were documented in extreme detail in their crimes, punishments, weight, height, scars, and tattoos. All of it. Yet, now they appear detached from a more individual or perhaps more personal recognition, like their name. I push aside my small feeling of confusion. But still, the way these faces are presented makes me uneasy somehow. I feel like a voyeur almost." (Journal transcription by author, 5 March, 2025).

My reflections here resonate with Drucker's (2021) discussion on information visualizations where she points out that "All visualizations are interpretations, not presentations of fact. Some graphic features of visualizations are artifacts of the display, not of the data, and can contribute to the reification of misinformation." (p. 99). In this instance, however, the surrounding context provides clarity regarding the use of these images. It did not mislead me in my experience, but it made me reflect on how easy it is to forget that while these photographs were taken with a

documentary purpose, their original intent was not for research but for institutional control. Following this, in my interview with Godfrey, he described how the project:

> "[...] was an attempt to do two things really. First was to recreate the studies from criminal lives on a much bigger scale so that we had stronger evidence to prove that people did desist from crime mainly. And the second thing was to democratize the data and to make it available to people who were interested in their own family histories." (B. Godfrey, personal communication, March 24, 2025)

Considering the project's goal to both scale up historical criminological research and make archival data broadly accessible, the decision to place these faces so prominently on the homepage becomes more complex. On one hand, it personalizes and humanizes the individuals behind the data. On the other hand, without names or further context, these faces risk becoming symbols rather than individuals. However, the site does provide specific details about these images, including the individuals' names, archival origins, and permission statements for their use. While this information is accessible, it is located separately from the homepage banner, thus requiring intentional searching from users. The decision to leave out names directly from the homepage could have been motivated by design or aesthetic reasons, unintentionally risking obscuring the humanizing information that the project does possess and shares elsewhere. I began to wonder whether this visual strategy supports the democratizing or humanizing intention or subtly undermines it by aestheticizing anonymity. This uncertainty reflects both a strength and a limitation of my approach. On one hand, the openness to ambiguity and subjective reflection encourages me to ask these questions, allowing for nuanced interpretations that acknowledge the emotional complexity of engaging with digitized materials. On the other hand, this very openness means I cannot offer a definitive answer or solution to the ethical tension I encountered. It is therefore important to recognize, once again, that my reflections are situated and interpretive rather than conclusive, and that this method privileges affective engagement and critical questioning over objective conclusions.

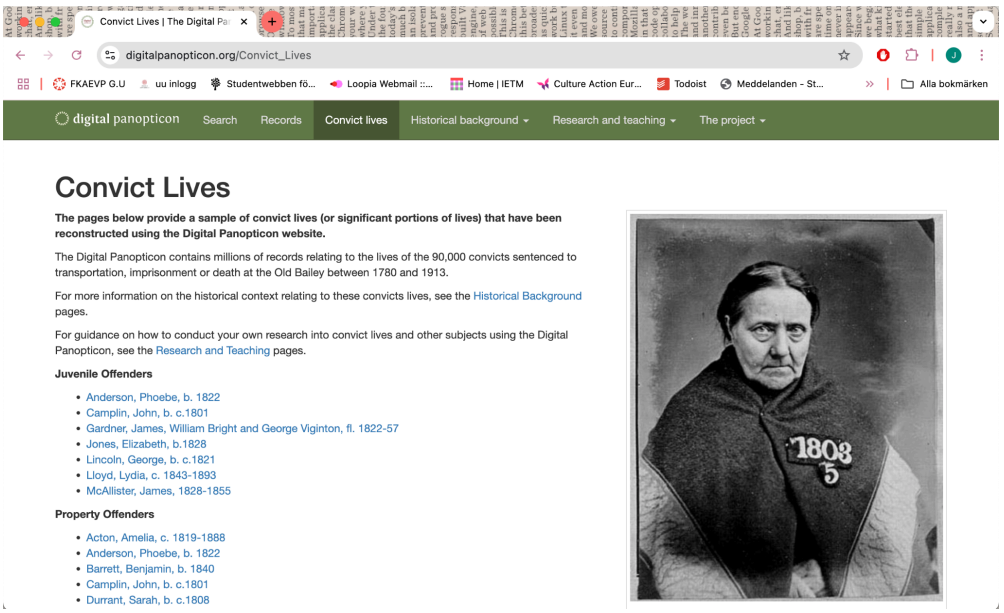


Figure 3. The Digital Panopticon. (2025). *Convict Lives*. Screenshot by author. https://www.digitalpanopticon.org/Convict_Lives

Moving forward, entering the category menu "Convict Lives" (*The Digital Panopticon*, n.d.), the page (see Figure 3) introduces the concept of reconstructing lives. The project describes its work as assembling significant portions of lives rather than complete narratives. This acknowledges that what is presented here is partial and shaped by both the possibilities and the limitations offered by the database rather than a full account of a person's existence. Below the introduction are categorized lists: Juvenile Offenders, Property Offenders, Violent Offenders, Other Offences, Transported, Imprisoned, Other Penal Outcomes, Recidivists, and Tattooed Convicts. The structure organizes people by the crimes they were convicted of and by the ways they intersected with the legal system.

From a critical perspective, categorizing individuals primarily by their crimes and interactions with the legal system risks simplifying the complexities of their lived experiences (Presner, 2016), defining them exclusively through their offenses and punishments. Such categorization may also unintentionally marginalize other significant dimensions of their lives, including social relationships, family backgrounds, personal struggles, and instances of resilience or resistance. Drawing on Rouhani's (2023) critique of digital heritage practices that fail to engage "...concerned communities, local stakeholders, and professionals in the process of selecting, presenting, and interpreting heritage can result in an elitist and reductionist approach to cultural heritage that reflects the cultural preferences of the tech projects rather than the concerned community" (p. 8), which highlights a need to consider who benefits from these digital reconstruction efforts. Although the *Digital Panopticon* focuses on criminal justice histories, relying solely on crime categories can establish a one-sided and potentially dehumanizing picture.

Furthermore, this categorization reflects the divisions of the legal system, which in itself is an expression of power and ideology. In line with this argument, Berry (2022) argues that the application of computation is not neutral but carries with it an imposed selectivity in how knowledge is transferred to data. The categories, although taken from historical legal terms, are not neutral descriptions but interpretations of actions taken within a specific historical and social context. A more ethical approach could involve explicitly problematizing these categories and examining their historical and social construction and the power relations they reflect (Glinka et al., 2015). Thus, from a critical standpoint, it is crucial to remain aware of how such categorical structures can impact modern interpretations and understandings of these reconstructed narratives.

Navigating further down on the page, my attention was drawn to a single photograph distinctly labeled with an individual's name of Sarah Durrant, captured in 1872.

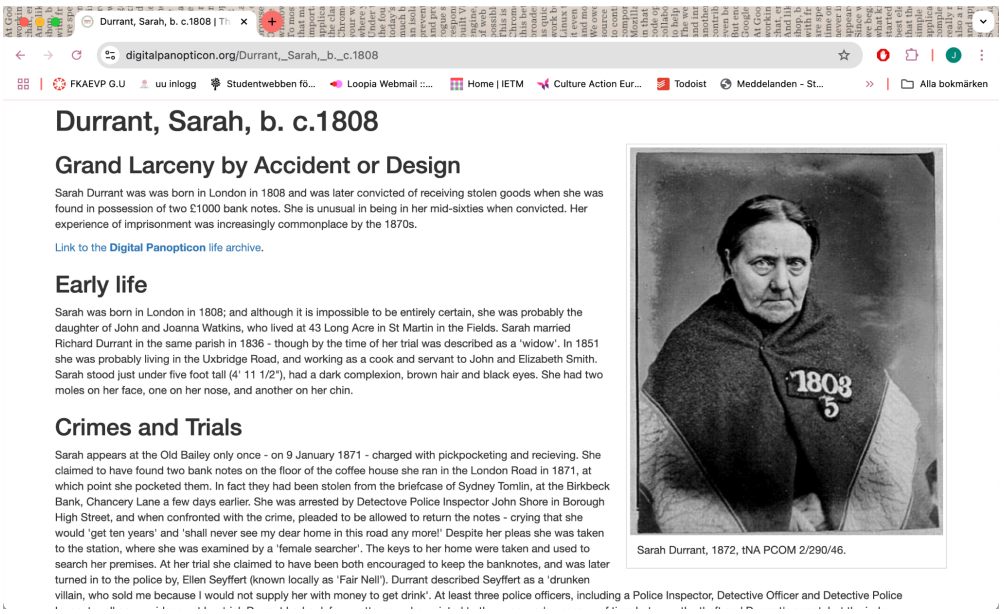


Figure 4. The Digital Panopticon. (2025). *Durrant, Sarah, b. c.1808*. Screenshot by author. https://www.digitalpanopticon.org/Durrant,_Sarah,_b._c.1808

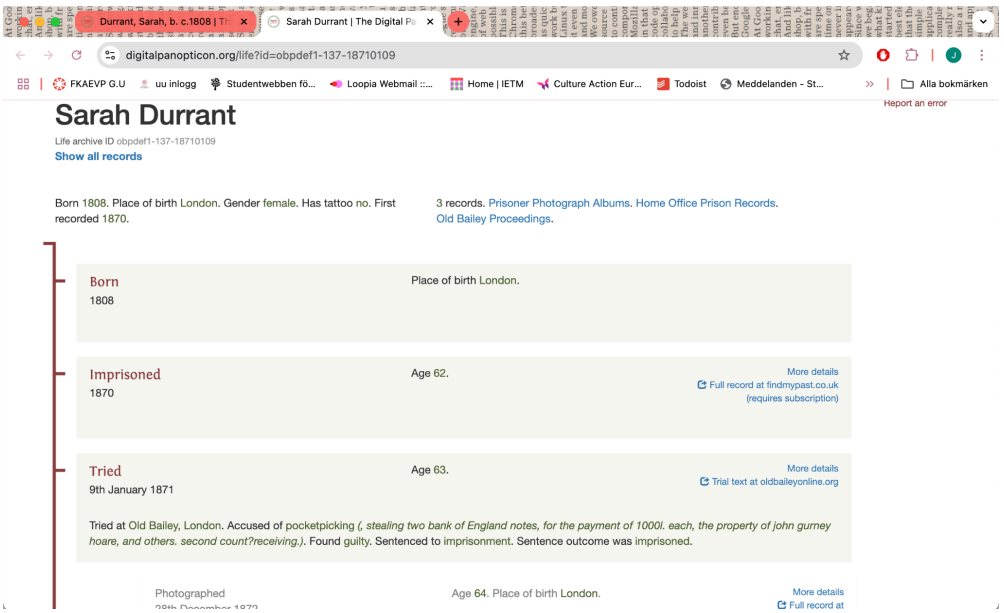


Figure 5. The Digital Panopticon. (2025). *Sarah Durrant*. Screenshot by author. https://www.digitalpanopticon.org/life?id=obpdef1-137-18710109

Opening Sarah Durrant's life page (see Figure 4), my attention was quickly grabbed by the title "*Grand Larceny by Accident or Design*" and I wrote in my field notes:

> "It's not just a statement but for me a question. I feel invited to wonder. Was this something she planned, or was she caught in something beyond her control? The introduction leans into that ambiguity. I notice how it doesn't try to resolve her guilt or innocence. Instead, it leaves room for interpretation. Was she an opportunist? Or simply in the wrong place at the wrong time? The phrasing seems intentional, designed to keep me questioning." (Journal transcription by author, 5 March, 2025).

As I continued reading, I noticed how the textual narrative did not overstate its authority. The presentation of Sarah Durrant was presented not as a definitive truth but as a reconstruction, stitched together from court records and prison logs (see Figure 5). This layering of fragmented data into a coherent narrative mirrors what Viola (2023) describes as post-authenticity (see section 4.1), a recognition that the digital reconstructions are not neutral windows into the past but mediated experiences shaped by the project's choices and interpretations. For example, I wrote in my journal:

> "Another detail now that catches my eye. Her age. She was in her sixties when she was convicted. The project notes that only three women over 60 were tried at the Old Bailey that year. Reading more closely, I realize how much of Sarah Durrant's story is shaped by guesswork, or educated, careful guesswork, yes, but still, fragments gathered from the margins. She "was probably" the daughter of John and Joanna Watkins. She "was likely" the cook for a couple in Uxbridge Road. And yet for someone who only appears

> once in court, she is strangely visible. There are physical details, her height, her complexion, the moles on her face, and these feel intimate in a way I didn't expect. They remind me that surveillance doesn't always arrive as visibility. Sometimes, it arrives as measurement." (Journal transcription by author, 5 March, 2025).

The choice to convey uncertainty by framing Durrant's narrative by using words such as *likely* and *probably* reminded me that what I was reading was not a complete truth but rather what could have been. This layering of facts, speculation, and historical context enabled me to understand Durrant's life not as a linear narrative but as an assemblage of moments that are partial, interpretive, and affective. As Viola (2023) writes about post-authenticity, these reconstructions resist closure and instead emphasize partiality and invite the reader into the archive's ambiguities. In that sense, the *Digital Panopticon* does not tell one story but holds multiple, layered possibilities together.

At this point, the life that emerged in front of me was not simply about crime and punishment but about a life intersecting with broader systems like poverty, gender, and legal power:

> "I'm also starting to see how her case is both personal and part of a bigger system. The act of finding and keeping stolen banknotes feels small and huge at the same time, depending on how I think about it. The notes were high-value and that alone transforms the offense into something bigger. But the way she's described, the way her story unfolds, doesn't suggest a criminal mastermind. I notice how the police searched her home and found only a few pounds and a stack of foreign letters under an assumed name. Why was she writing letters abroad? Was she running from something? Or simply trying to hold something together? And then there's Ellen Seyffert…Their relationship is possibly a partnership in running the coffee house, maybe, something more is described as "fragile," and I keep thinking about that word. Her respectability - fragile. Her finances - fragile. Her connections to others - fragile. But her voice, even reported secondhand, is strong. When arrested, she cried out, begging to return the notes, saying she would never see her dear home again. Even though she was in a fragile environment, she does not seem driven by fear of punishment but by attachment. To place." (Journal transcription by author, 5 March, 2025).

This reflection marked a shift in how I engaged with the narrative. Rather than reading Sarah Durrant's case as a closed legal story, I began to understand it as a layered narrative shaped by emotion and social entanglements. This invited me to reflect on how the *Digital Panopticon* does not pretend to have every answer in its reconstruction of "Convict Lives". Instead, it remains transparent and reconstructs as much as it can while acknowledging the limits. As Godfrey pointed out during our conversation:

> "...the way we reconstructed those lives is the way that you can reconstruct anybody's life in our, in the digital panopticon. So it was a way of showing people what they could do. And indeed, they could go much further by doing their own historical research. They could add color to the lives, details of where the people lived, what prisons they'd served in, what conditions they would've been under. You could do much more. You could write an essay on every single person in that." (B. Godfrey, personal communication, March 24, 2025).

In response to this, it is interesting how Godfrey (2016), in his article *Liquid Crime History: Digital entrepreneurs and the industrial production of 'ruined lives'*, discusses how biographical research can push back against simplified or deterministic understandings of complex life stories. Godfrey (2016) writes that "From the huge number of digital lives, the individual will emerge" (p. 151), suggesting that the real power of these digital reconstructions does not lie in reinforcing categories but in surfacing more nuanced perspectives of a person's life. However, Godfrey (2016) also points to a tension between the promise of individual lives emerging and the huge volume of them threatening to overwhelm the receiver. Godfrey (2016) asks, "Do the websites which reveal a wealth of biographical data on thousands of 'ruined lives' risk engendering 'ruin-fatigue'?" (p. 150). This concern about ruin-fatigue, the exhaustion or desensitization that may arise when confronted with an overwhelming number of tragic or difficult life stories, raises important questions about how digital platforms mediate ethical engagement. Godfrey's (2016) observation points to a structural issue within digital heritage projects, the tension between accessibility and affect. The scale and speed of digital access, while empowering in some aspects, can also flatten emotional response.

Following this discussion, during our meeting, Godfrey further described an ethical dilemma the project team faced at the end of the project:

> "I think we mainly did it for students and researchers to show what you could do in terms of reconstructing lives[...] we tried not to be too sensationalistic about it. That was another thing that occurred to us at the end of our project really when we saw how students were using it. Students loved the sensationalist crimes when they were searching for a study to do with one of our undergraduate courses that asked them to use digital panopticon to reconstruct a life. They weren't picking people who had committed low level crimes. They wanted to do rape or sexual violence. Not much we can do about that. If you make a source available, then people will look at what they want to look at[...] that is one ethical thing, which I don't think we could solve. Only if we blocked out, salacious cases, which we're never gonna do. We wanted it all out there." (B. Godfrey, personal communication, March 24, 2025).

What Godfrey articulates here is not simply about student preferences. It is about what happens when difficult histories become searchable, sortable, and narratively

appealing. What does it mean when violence becomes a compelling entry point rather than a moment of pause? Godfrey's reflection that once something is online, "people will look at what they want to look at" feels uncomfortably true. However, from my own exploration of the reconstructed narratives, this method of digitally reimagining historical records offered the potential to directly challenge the risk of "ruin-fatigue" that Godfrey (2016) describes. Rather than flattening these lives into endless data points, the reconstructed narrative of Sarah Durrant revealed not only institutional trajectories but also personal resilience, contradiction, and a human voice. But there is a loss of control that comes with open access, especially when working with histories shaped by suffering, shame, or vulnerability. And yet, withholding those materials would reproduce its own kind of erasure. From a CDH perspective, this suggests that the way digital archives structure and present sensitive personal narratives matters profoundly. When the interface slows the user down, embeds context, and represents the partial and situated nature of the archival material, it can support more sensitive and inclusive modes of engagement. Thus, while digital tools can risk flattening experience, they can also be used to reanimate complexity. CDH points out that digital archives are not simply sites of access but of interpretation, where ethical and affective relationships to historical subjects are formed. My engagement showcases that, far from creating detachment, this reconstructed narrative offered the potential to disrupt the kinds of consumption Godfrey critiques, offering a more responsible and reflective way of encountering difficult pasts.

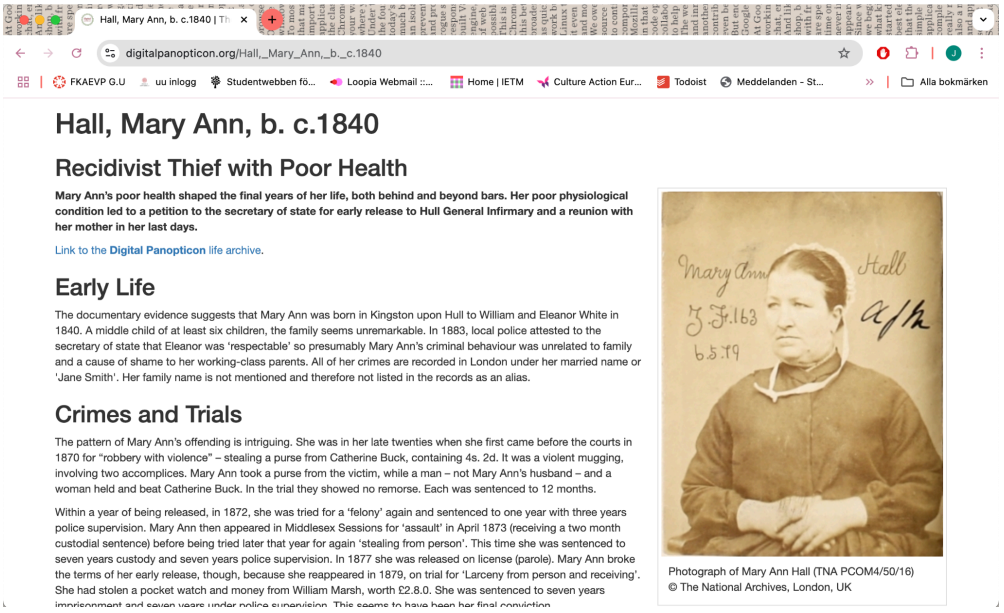


Figure 6. The Digital Panopticon. (2025). *Hall, Mary Ann, b. c.1840*. Screenshot by author. https://www.digitalpanopticon.org/Hall,_Mary_Ann,_b._c.1840

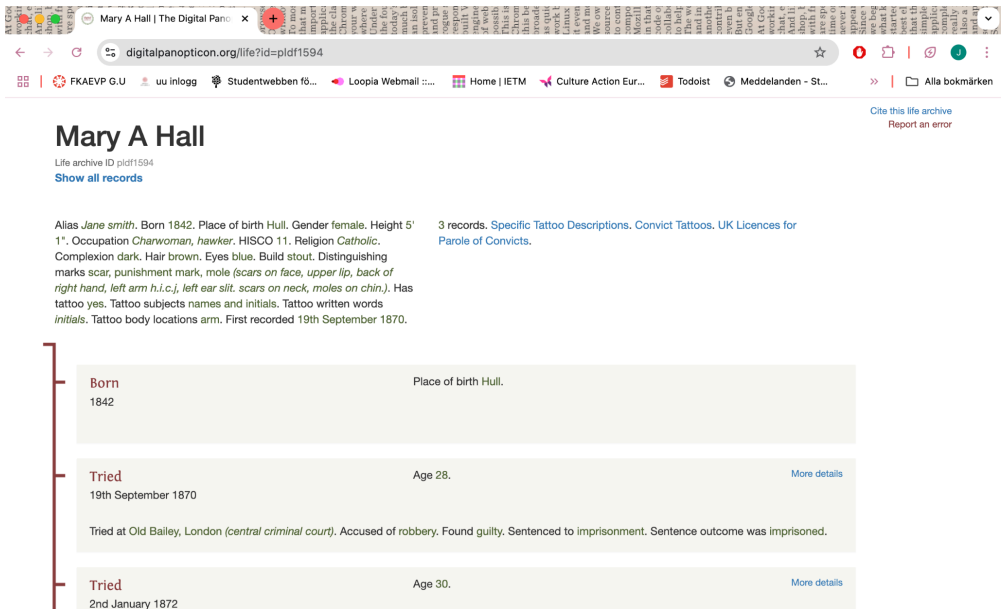


Figure 7. The Digital Panopticon. (2025). *Mary A Hall*. Screenshot by author. https://www.digitalpanopticon.org/life?id=pldf1594

Prompted by this, to further study another personal story reconstructed by the *Digital Panopticon,* I chose to engage with the history of Mary Ann Hall (see Figures 6 and 7). Mary Ann Hall was listed under the previously described "Imprisoned" category, and unlike many of the others' names in this category, her image, like Sarah Durrant's, appeared beside her story. Therefore, I chose to continue my exploration by learning more about Hall's life. However, entering this life story, I was quickly faced with an uncomfortable feeling:

> "A bold headline confronts me "Recidivist Thief with Poor Health". That is the introduction…a label leading me. Criminal behavior paired with a medical condition. I feel like that is how I am told to see her. The framing decides before I do. Compared to Sarah Durrant's story, which left space for complexity or ambiguity… Mary Ann's entry feels predetermined…I understand where it comes from. It is not invented it reflects the language of the records, the institutional voice that documented her. But I still pause. Do we have to meet her like this? What does it mean to lead with this summary, this judgment? I do not expect the project to overwrite the past. But I do wonder. Because now I feel more cautious." (Journal transcription by author, 7 March, 2025).

As Rouse (2019) argues, the act of telling someone else's story in a digital space is never neutral. Even when working with archival material, the choices in framing, design, and presentation carry weight. They could signal to users how to interpret a life, how to feel, and where to focus. So perhaps the question is not whether to include a label like "Recidivist Thief with Poor Health", but whether there is a need to lead with it. In terms of how CDH challenges the neutrality of digital preservation and categorization, this moment with Mary Ann Hall's life presentation became especially revealing. The way her story is introduced shows how the ideological frameworks of the original records can still remain embedded in the digital interface

(Risam, 2018). This is not simply a case of presenting historical facts but a case of how those facts are framed, ordered, and foregrounded through specific choice (Risam, 2018).

This is echoed by the *Digital Panopticon* team themselves, who acknowledge that the records themselves dictate this selection, while also recognizing that their presentation "arguably reproduces the racist, gendered and imperialist categories of the nineteenth-century British state" (Godfrey et al., n.d., para 1). This recognition complicates the idea of objective data access and reimagination. What appears to be a simple archival presentation may reinforce the classificatory logic of the penal system itself. Even though the project aims to democratize access and offer new perspectives on penal history, it simultaneously reanimates historical labels of deviance and difference, which raises questions about how users, especially descendants or casual browsers, are encouraged to perceive these lives.

Building on this, in terms of disclosive ethics, Proferes (2020) highlights how "...a researcher may choose to think about their project from the perspective of respect for persons, beneficence, and justice" (p. 424), which Godfrey touched upon in our meeting:

> "What we wanted to do was to reveal working class, the history of working class people, really history from below to bring their experiences into the public world. But what we thought we had done at the end when we reconsidered was we had done that for white people…we've produced white people's history for white people to study. So we then pivoted quite a bit…to look at indigenous incarceration in Australia and African American incarceration in the United States, and to use all of the techniques that we'd used in a digital panopticon, but to bring them to non-white populations. So that their histories could also be revealed. So I think, but it only occurred to us at the end when we look back to see what we'd done, that was the only point where we thought this is not very diverse history that we have made here."(B. Godfrey, personal communication, March 24, 2025).

Godfrey's important note here is further discussed on the *Digital Panopticon* page titled *The Ethics of Digital Data on Convict Lives,* where they transparently state that less than a quarter of the records reproduced by the project relate to women, with an even smaller number concerning Aboriginal Australians or Black Londoners. Thus, the focus on young, white, British and Irish males obscures the broader contexts of imperial expansion, Indigenous massacres, and global systems of forced labour, ultimately narrowing the understanding of colonial power by drawing the attention "away from the complex exercise of racial and gendered power, and focussing that attention on the single relationship between white, male convicts and the state" (Godfrey et al., n.d. para. 19). As a digital humanities master's student, I first encountered Roopika Risam's (2018) critical work on the complex politics of decolonization in digital humanities during my coursework. Risam's (2018) discussion helped me recognize that this situation could be described as an example of how ideological frameworks and invisible biases can be embedded in digital humanities projects. This showcases how important it is to have critical self-reflection and a conscious work towards the decolonization of digital

archives. Risam (2018) emphasizes that decolonization is not just about adding more diverse groups but is a historical process that requires a fundamental change in how knowledge is produced and represented. The project's recognition that their initial work was "not very diverse" and ongoing work toward redressing this imbalance signals an important step toward reflexivity in digital scholarship. However, as scholars like Risam (2018) and Berry (2022) highlight, such efforts must go beyond surface-level inclusion to interrogate the ethical, structural, and technical foundations of digital heritage projects, to move toward a critical and decolonial practice that not only recovers these marginalized voices but also reimagines the systems through which knowledge is contextualized, mediated, and made meaningful.

Following this, another ethical concern Godfrey mentioned during our meeting was how the project chose not to anonymize names or create pseudonyms for the digitized personal records. Due to the project's methodology of record linkage, that is "algorithmically connecting data based on names and other personal characteristics" (Godfrey et al., n.d., para. 6), and use of already publicly available data, anonymizing names would not allow users to test the research process or verify the connections made by this approach. However, Godfrey et al. (n.d.) also note the emotional impact that reinterpretation can have. For example, "descendants researching their ancestors...may find information they would prefer not to know" (Godfrey et al. n.d., para. 8). This, again, points to a critical tension between access and affect. As Smythe and Murray (2010) emphasize, the emotional risks of narrative research often stem from the reinterpretation of personal stories through institutional and academic lenses. While their discussion centers on living participants, their concern about the authoritative power of the researcher, to "...renarrate a life unasked" (Smythe & Murray, 2010, p. 322), resonates in digital reconstructions of historical lives, where interpretive framing may still feel intrusive or reductive, especially when shaped by the project's disciplinary and technological structure.

In this light, the framing of Mary Ann Hall's story is not simply a design decision but an ethical decision about tone, invitation, and emotional weight. However, in my engagement with Mary Ann Hall's digitally reconstructed life, I reflected on how the narrative differed significantly when told as a partial story rather than accessed as a timeline. While reading a timeline offered a more detached, factual perspective of her institutional journey, encountering her reconstructed narrative introduced an interpretative complexity. Rather than passively receiving administrative facts, I found myself actively reconsidering her lived experience through an affective lens that the narrative imposed:

> "What stays with me most is how central her body becomes in her narrative. Her weight, her illnesses, her scars. Early on, when she complains of pain, she's dismissed as malingering. Later, when her condition deteriorates beyond denial, her illness transforms her from inmate to burden. Knowing this from her perspective makes me weak…I mean the records dehumanize on purpose, but…in surviving, they leave behind the possibility of rehumanization" (Journal transcription by author, 7 March, 2025).

This process of reshaping historical material aligns with what Dobson (2019) refers to as deformation, by defamiliarizing Hall's documentation in extracting it from its institutional frame and recasting it as a narrative with emotional weights, made me wonder how much her repeated unlawful actions were shaped by the state of her health and how her ongoing incarceration in turn influenced her illness. In this way, the project opened new interpretive possibilities and made me question whether her treatment, or lack thereof, made it difficult for her to change course. Presenting and reimagining the sensitive material in new, unfamiliar ways encouraged empathy for me, though this might not be the case for everyone. Therefore, the project must be transparent about how it links, categorizes, and interprets the data to maintain both its methodological integrity and its ethical responsibilities.

6.3 Creative reimagining of incarceration narratives in Ironclad Sisterhood

In this section, I turn to the *Ironclad Sisterhood* project, shifting focus toward how this digital heritage platform constructs and reimagines the lives of Amelia Hatfield (1792–1841) and Margaret Southern (1783–1859). As with the previous section, my analysis draws on digital autoethnography to explore how I, situated within my position as a digital humanities master's student, interpret and experience the narrative strategies shaped by the platform. Rather than striving for neutrality, I allow emotion and hesitation to guide the process of interpretation. This interpretive mode guided questions of ethics that became especially present through my interview with Andrew Redfern, the project's coordinator.

Redfern's reflections provided insight into the motivations, challenges, and ethical dilemmas faced by the *Ironclad Sisterhood* team as they attempted to balance historical accuracy with creative reimagination. His perspective offered a layered view of the responsibilities of digital memory work. The aim here was again not to assess the project as a fixed product but rather to reflect on how my experience of engaging with it shaped the way I encountered these individuals and considered their historical presence.

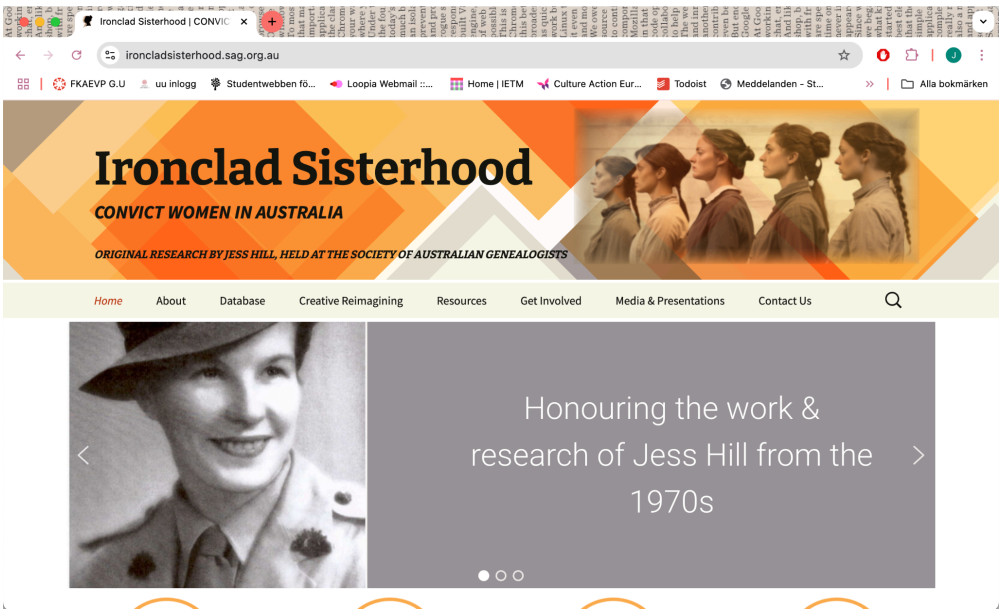


Figure 8. Ironclad Sisterhood. (2025). *Main page*. Screenshot by author. https://ironcladsisterhood.sag.org.au/

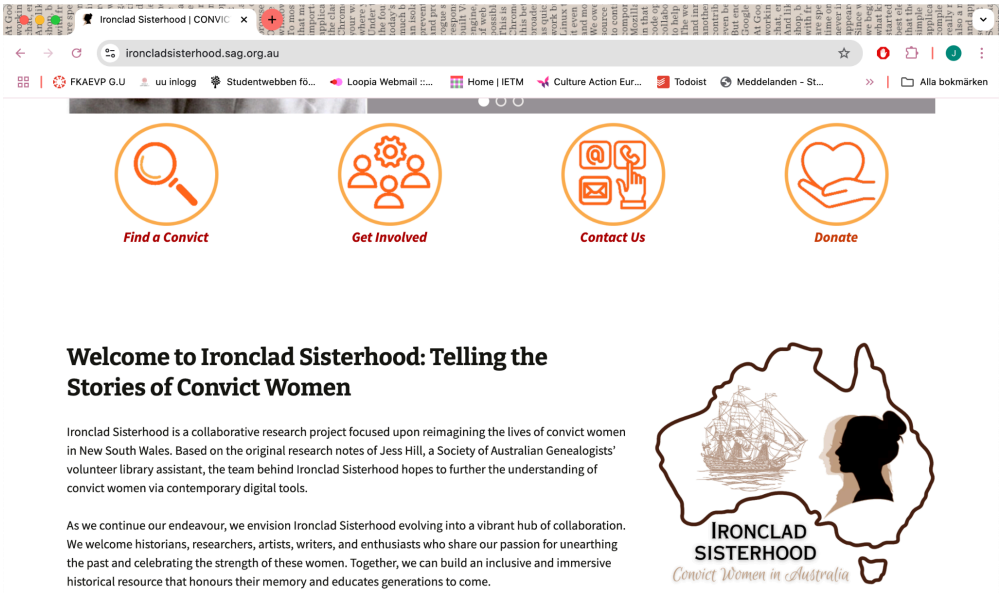


Figure 9. Ironclad Sisterhood. (2025). *Main page, further down the page*. Screenshot by author. https://ironcladsisterhood.sag.org.au/

As introduced earlier, the *Ironclad Sisterhood* project builds upon Jess Hill's handwritten research notes, now digitised and partially reimagined through a combination of archival transcription, creative biography, and AI-generated imagery (Ironclad Sisterhood, n.d.). When I first visited the homepage (see Figures 8 and 9), I was met with a similar experience to that of the *Digital Panopticon* project in how the banner images again created a feeling that was difficult to articulate. I wrote in my journal:

> "Five women, turned slightly away, their heads tilted together, gazing off into the same direction. None of them meet my eyes. I don't know who they are. They aren't introduced. They appear not as individuals but as a collective symbol. Of what exactly, I am not sure yet. Maybe they are meant to create the idea of female imprisonment. Maybe they are a gesture toward solidarity or anonymity. But something about their positioning leaves me confused. It is like they are leading me somewhere but not looking back to see if I am following." (Journal transcription by author, 10 March, 2025).

With my previous knowledge about the project's use of artificial intelligence to generate images, I interpreted these individuals not as real people but as symbolic representations rather than historical specificity. However, with a lack of direct information in connection with these images, the risk is that they may be perceived as authentic visual records rather than speculative representations that could blur the line between historical evidence and creative reconstruction. As Amaral (2024) argues, AI-generated imagery, when crafted to imitate historical photographs or moments, carries the danger of "masquerading as historical fact" (Amaral, 2024, para. 8). The emotional realism of these images can make them powerfully persuasive, even when entirely fabricated (Amaral, 2024). Thus, these visuals risk contributing to an unethical or distorted public memory without sufficient labeling or contextual framing.

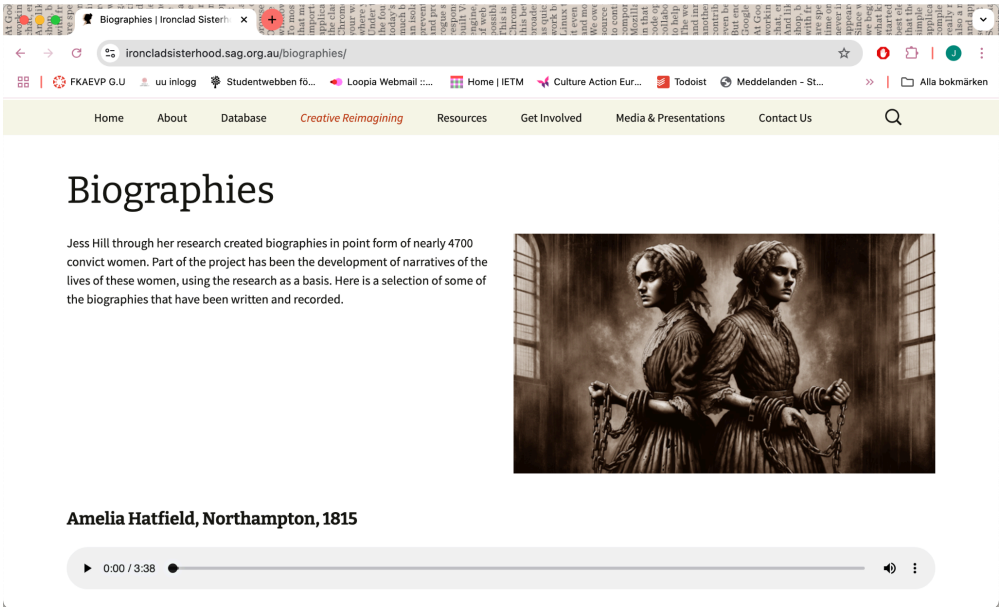


Figure 10. Ironclad Sisterhood. (2025). *Biographies*. Screenshot by author. https://ironcladsisterhood.sag.org.au/biographies/

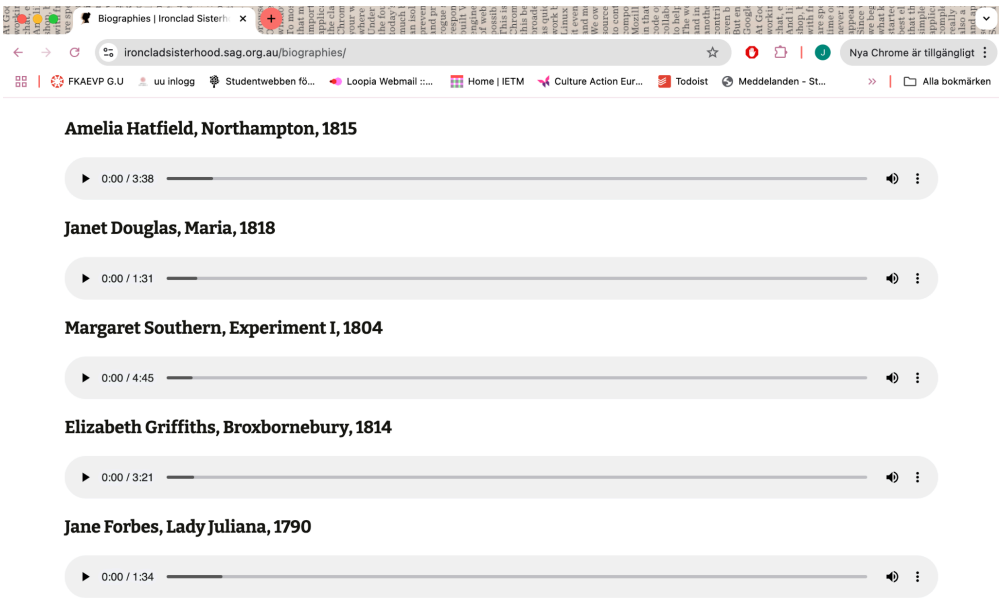


Figure 11. Ironclad Sisterhood. (2025). *Biographies, further down the page*. Screenshot by author. https://ironcladsisterhood.sag.org.au/biographies/

Building on this discussion, I was again unsure of how to interpret the image when I entered the *Biographies* page (see Figure 10), where the project has developed narratives of the lives represented in the records based on Jess Hill's research. In my journal, I wrote:

> "So is this supposed to represent the women in the datasets? Is it symbolic? It definitely makes me more emotional. Should I be emotional? With a strange but also curious feeling…But since no photographs seems to exist, maybe this is how I can understand that the people documented are real people and not just simply history? I do not know whether this image helps me connect or understand or confuses me more of their experience. Who are they supposed to be in this context?" (Journal transcription by author, 10 March, 2025).

This concern I experienced is relevant in a digital heritage context, where the intent is remembrance, not deception. In my meeting with Redfern, he discussed how the project faced this ethical challenge:

> "We wouldn't create an image unless we had a physical description of the woman in the records... but then some of them we were actually limited by the AI tools because it wouldn't create women with scars[...] trying to be authentic, but also trying to use the tools. Sometimes there was a conflict there[...] we had to water it down[...] We very quickly[...] realized that we needed to mark them as AI-generated. So we put a watermark on all the images that we created[...] The big criticism from users was it was all too stereotypical… We responded to that[...] by adding more information[...] where we explained our critical fabulation and...the process that we used to go about it." (A. Redfern, personal communication, March 13, 2025).

Redfern's reflection highlights both the project's sensitivity to visual ethics and the practical limitations imposed by the AI tools used. However, while the inclusion of watermarks on some AI-generated images signals an awareness of ethical responsibility, this measure should extend to all AI-mediated visuals presented through the platform interface. Without clear contextualization or attribution, these prominently displayed images risk reinforcing the very confusion and emotional tension I described in my autoethnographic journaling. The absence of a visible label or explanation could, therefore, invite users to interpret them as authentic archival material rather than as speculative reconstructions based on limited descriptive data. However, Redfern's transparency regarding the decision to watermark images, along with the project team's acknowledgment of mixed user responses, exemplifies the kind of reflexive practice that Kelley (2020) emphasizes in her ethics of goodwill, where "...responsible researchers must always interrogate their assumptions, premises, questions, goals, and methods" (p. 451). This kind of reflexivity is also central to Viola's (2023) perspective on how graphical design and the methods applied should "...expose inconsistencies and cast doubts on the digital object and to create a space for interpretation, rather than to provide one" (p. 124). From these perspectives, all of the AI-generated images, especially when framed as historical, must be accompanied by visible markers of their speculative nature, not only to maintain transparency but to acknowledge their position within a broader network of mediated knowledge production.

Moving forward in my digital autoethnographic journey, as I scrolled further down the *Biographies* page (see Figure 11), I was presented with a curated list of audio files of life stories. Each recorded biography offered an audio narration but no accompanying written text. This decision to privilege voice over text changed the nature of interaction for me, following a slower, more embodied mode of engagement. Wanting to immerse myself more fully in the mediated lives presented here, I selected two narratives to explore in greater depth. Of the existing recorded biographies available through the platform at the time of my fieldwork, I chose to focus on those with the longest audio recordings. This selection was grounded in the assumption that the longer recordings might contain more elaborate narratives, offering richer insight into the creative interpretive work developed by the project.

This decision led me to the audio-recorded story of Amelia Hatfield, who, at the age of twenty-two, was transported to Australia to serve a fourteen-year sentence for possession of a forged banknote. Hatfield arrived in colonial Australia in 1815 aboard the *Northampton* ship with her three children, attempting to keep her family together within a system not designed for that care. The voice of the narrator describes what the records have documented about her conviction and life, and Hatfield's story unfolds as one of repeated petitions, institutional separations, and quiet acts of resistance. As I engaged with her biography, I found myself not only absorbing a narrated reconstruction of her life but also reflecting on the narrative strategies that shaped my experience. Listening, rather than reading about this life shifted the mode of engagement from information retrieval to emotional connection. In my field notes, I described this moment:

> "And when I hear that Amelia was transported at 22 for possessing a forged note, with three small children, something in me sinks. Her six-year-old son listed for an orphanage four years after they arrived. Her other son running away at sixteen to try and find her again. The weight of that moment lands heavy. I am sitting with this history in a new way. It is no longer just about piecing together timelines. It is about emotion at this stage for me. This is worth knowing. With what isn't recorded, with what might have been felt. I feel pulled in." (Journal transcription by author, 10 March 2025)

The emotional impact of the narrative is shaped by both archival traces and creative storytelling. Redfern further highlighted this in our meeting, where he emphasized how the project aims to lift these stories off the page to make sure that not only facts and dates are accessible, but also how the story of these women can be told and retold in a creative way. This dual method reflects the project's use of the concept of critical fabulation by Saidiya Hartman (2008) as described by the project, where "historical and archival research is combined with critical theory and fictional narrative to fill in the blanks left in the historical record" (Ironclad Sisterhood, n.d.). This was further described by Redfern in our interview:

> "We were taking the information that we found in the research and other data sets[...] and then building narratives around that. And if there were bits missing, we were creating informed guesses about what would've been the experience of those women at the time using other experiences that we knew about."(A. Redfern, personal communication, March 13, 2025).

This approach acknowledges the gaps and silences in sensitive archival material while acknowledging the assumptions made of those voids (Dobson, 2019). Yet, it also introduces curatorial power (Boyles, 2018). With over 4700 women in their dataset, only a select few are represented through voiced, creative narratives. I wrote:

> "The biographies here are curated, and that makes me more aware of how much my interpretations must shape how I see this history. The effort to give presence to women who history has largely erased is deeply valuable. But I also notice how much of that presence is a construction, grounded in research, yes, but still crafted into a narrative, shaped through someone, which I do not know who, chooses." (Journal transcription by author, 10 March 2025)

Being transparent about who and how these biographies were selected to be mediated in this way is crucial, as curatorial power inherently shapes public understanding, visibility, and memory (Boyles, 2018). However, as Boyles (2018) also highlights, curatorial practices can empower marginalized voices and engage audiences in critical reflection and information ethics about narratives previously undervalued or overshadowed by dominant histories and stereotypes. The very act of curating these biographies can serve as a powerful pedagogical tool, encouraging users, much as I experienced with Amelia Hatfield's narrative, to gain a richer understanding of incarceration history from a lived perspective. Thus challenging historical erasures and promoting a more inclusive and socially conscious collective

memory (see Thorell, 2018; Axelsson Yngvéus et al, 2023). However, while the project explains its use of critical fabulation, further transparency about the curatorial process, specifically, who is narrating these stories and why and how they were selected, would deepen its ethical commitment. As Kelley (2020) argues in her framework of goodwill ethics, ethical research requires a sustained dedication to transparency regarding goals, methods, and audiences. Such transparency not only fosters trust but also "...demonstrates respect for the people that one researches, whether these people are the direct focus or not" (Kelley, 2020, p. 452). In this context, sharing the rationale behind the narrative choices and the voices chosen to tell them would enhance the project's ethical grounding and invite users into a more accountable and participatory engagement with the past.

Continuing from here, I pressed play on the audio recording titled "Margaret Southern, Experiment I, 1804" (see Figure 11), where I experienced different feelings and interpreted the narrative differently than Hatfield's life. Margaret Southern was sentenced to seven years' transportation to Australia for stealing clothes and arrived in colonial New South Wales in 1804 aboard the *Experiment* ship. Upon arrival, Margaret established a life with another imprisoned individual named John Parkes, with whom she had eleven children, creating a legacy within the growing colony despite the absence of official marriage records. Margaret's narrative, for me, portrayed a life shaped by resilience and adaptation. I wrote in my journal:

> "Like Amelia, Margaret was transported. Sentenced, placed aboard a ship, carried into the unknown. But where Amelia's narrative felt fractured, children separated, systems interrupting her attempts to live freely. Margaret's life starts to unfold with a quiet sense of momentum. There is hardship, yes. But there is also growth. Soon after arriving, Margaret forms a partnership, raises a family. Eleven children. Some of their names become known in the colony. Her life expands outward. There is continuity. Legacy. I didn't expect that." (Journal transcription by author, 10 March 2025)

Reflecting on these two biographies highlights how drastically the lived experiences and outcomes for transported women could differ, even though both Amelia Hatfield and Margaret Southern faced similar sentences and conditions of incarceration during the same era. Amelia's narrative, marked by separation and struggle, contrasts with Margaret's life, which unfolds through resilience, partnership, and a lasting familial legacy. My interpretation of these differences is, however, undoubtedly shaped by how each narrative has been documented, reimagined, and mediated. The curator's choices, emphasizing institutional hardships for Amelia or familial continuity for Margaret, strongly influenced my response, drawing attention to the curatorial power involved in constructing these stories. Yet, as Boyles (2018) argues, creating and presenting these narratives from marginalized historical perspectives can itself be understood as a critical act. It highlights the variability and complexity of experiences among transported individuals, challenging simplistic or generalized understandings of incarceration history. By drawing attention to the differences, these curated narratives can invite users to reflect more deeply on how historical experiences are represented and also remembered, to explore this history from alternative and nuanced perspectives.

However, this makes the project's transparency around its methodology even more crucial when engaging in creative storytelling practices that draw from, but inevitably go beyond, the archival record. As Redfern pointed out in our conversation, the project's foundation rests on Jess Hill's 1970s handwritten research, which was pioneering in its focus on incarcerated women, a group historically underrepresented in both academic and public history. In continuing this work through digital means, Redfern acknowledged a core ethical dilemma in how to honour the integrity of Hill's original research while introducing new interpretive layers that bring these women's stories to life. Redfern explained that the decision to include these stories was not taken lightly and that the team deliberately framed them within the method of critical fabulation, as he described:

> "So our focus was to try and maintain the integrity of Jess's research and continue her goal of trying to bring out these unknown people in our research. The men are very well researched, but the women are often hidden in our archives and our record sets. So constantly going back to the records and constantly going back to the original research. We wanted to really honor that. But also, how do we then use modern tools, modern digitization, modern digital tools to tell the story? Because with family history, which is the area that we work in it's so much about the stories. You can read facts on a page, but if you put that together in a, some sort of story, that's what people really attach themselves to and get interested in and intrigued by." (A. Redfern, personal communication, March 13, 2025).

This tension between historical accuracy and narrative empathy emerged as an ongoing ethical challenge. As Redfern emphasized, the need to continuously return to the records, cross-check interpretations, and make space for gaps was important to ethically consider the interpretative nature of the creatively reimagined narratives created. This observation aligns with Jenny Kidd's (2017) argument that digital heritage encounters can actively reframe historical narratives by fostering multisensory, embodied, and empathetic engagement. During my digital humanities studies, I came across Kidd's (2017) participatory research on *With New Eyes I See* (WNEIS), an immersive project that projected untold wartime narratives of botanist Cyril Mortimer Green onto Cardiff's civic landscape. Kidd (2017) illustrates how narrative and digital techniques can transform complex archival material into layered, emotionally resonant experiences that deepen public understanding of difficult pasts. While Kidd (2017) discusses emerging XR technologies and multimodal environments, it is the interactive and affective structuring of historical biography that resonated with my own experience of engaging with incarceration narratives. As Redfern emphasized, it is through storytelling rather than fact alone that audiences can become "interested in and intrigued by" historical lives. Kidd's (2017) research similarly highlights how participants formed attachments to the figure of Cyril not simply through facts but through the narrative strategies that foregrounded his absence, loss, and embodied presence.

However, Kidd (2017) also records moments when the participants struggled to connect and understand, or questioned the authenticity of the emotional cues. These varied responses, and the subjective nature of engaging with reconstructed historical documents, underscore that emotional engagement is not guaranteed but

constructed, raising critical ethical questions. As Kidd (2017) asks, "...to what degree is the manipulation of empathy ethically defensible?" (p. 64). This is not a question with a definitive answer, but rather an ongoing discussion within both digital humanities and historical research, where audience interpretation and narrative responsibility continue to be actively negotiated (Kidd, 2017; Viola, 2023). But, drawing on Kidd's (2017) emphasis on silence and ambiguity as deliberate narrative tools, in connection to Redfern's insistence on honoring archival gaps and using them as spaces for empathetic reimagining, both challenge traditional assumptions of neutrality and objectivity, demonstrating instead how creative digital practices can reveal the interpretive labor involved in shaping and understanding history. In this sense, the *Ironclad Sisterhood* project's use of critical fabulation and multisensory storytelling can create a form of engagement that makes marginalized lives visible and opens up new dialogues around memory, power, and representation. However, to minimize the risk that the line between historical evidence and creative reconstruction becomes blurred, the *Ironclad Sisterhood* project's reflexive stance, its commitment to documenting its own process, and making its interpretive framework visible, becomes crucial to ethically ground its digital approach to mediate incarceration narratives to contemporary audiences.

6.4 Ethical strategies for digital incarceration narratives

This section presents a thematic overview of my digital autoethnographic exploration and the insights gathered from the interviews with Andrew Redfern (*Ironclad Sisterhood*) and Barry Godfrey (*Digital Panopticon*). By placing my embodied experience alongside the perspectives of the two project practitioners, I analyze what ethical strategies and challenges emerged from engaging with the digital reconstructions of historical incarceration narratives. Through this comparative and thematic analysis, several key themes emerged: constructing incarceration narratives could be both interpretive and ethical, avoiding sensationalistic portrayals, creating space for interpretive pause, reflexivity, and methodological transparency, which revealed ethical strategies and challenges in how incarcerated individuals are mediated through digital platforms. The themes identified here also represent the main results of this thesis, and they are further discussed in the following subsections.

6.4.1 Reconstructing narratives as ethical engagement

During my digital autoethnographic exploration, these platforms did more than give me access to and present historical documents, they animated the archive by interpreting and reconstructing the fragmented sensitive materials to create a narrative that invited emotional engagement and a deeper sense of relational connection to the lives behind the records. Both the *Digital Panopticon* and *Ironclad Sisterhood* demonstrate how the historical incarcerated lives were not isolated but entangled within wider structures of poverty and legal authority. In my engagement with the *Digital Panopticon*, it was Sarah Durrant's story that initially disrupted my sense of detached observation. Her life unfolded as a portrait of fragile respectability, intersecting with mechanisms of surveillance and punishment. Her conviction, framed ambiguously under the title "Grand Larceny by Accident or

Design", left space for uncertainty, not closure. That ambiguity, rather than distancing me, drew me in. I began to recognize how a single encounter with the justice system could redefine a life, but now making it readable not only through state documentation. Yet, it was not only Sarah Durrant. I encountered reconstructed narratives of Mary Ann Hall, Amelia Hatfield, and Margaret Southern that made me feel increasingly less like a voyeur and more like a witness, invested in the complexities of these individuals' realities. These were not just names or statistics but partial stories reanimated through interpretation. The tension between data and humanity remained, but it was softened by the ways fragments were woven into narratives. These modes of storytelling invited not just curiosity, but emotional presence. They allowed me to connect and reflect on the lives beyond the documents, to understand incarceration as an experience deeply embedded in broader societal injustices rather than reducible to isolated acts of crime or punishment.

As Redfern noted during our conversation, the *Ironclad Sisterhood* project itself embodies a reflexive awareness of the ethical implications of its work. What began as a digitization initiative grew into an exercise in narrative reimagining, grounded in interpretive methods:

> "I think if you can stay firm and stay focused on what your goals are and what you're trying to achieve and being open about that. It can provide another voice of these women. We're not saying it's the only voice. We're not saying it's the ultimate voice. And this is, I think, part of the nature of historical research. We are looking at these in 2025. A woman looked at them in 1970. Someone is probably going to look at them again in 2050 with a different lens. Realizing that you are part of an ongoing understanding of these historical records." (A. Redfern, personal communication, March 13, 2025)

In this way, constructing these narratives is not only an interpretive act but could be understood as an ethical stance in itself. This process allowed me to view the realities of historical incarceration within broader social terms, beyond the convictions themselves, emphasizing relational, systemic, and affective dimensions often erased from archival visibility. Moreover, as Godfrey (2016) suggests, "The more opportunities that can be provided for academics, museum curators and website designers to use biographical data, the greater the chance of undermining easy assumptions about the lives of the poor, and the less chance of ruin-fatigue." (p. 151). Through that recognition, I engaged not only with what the archives revealed, but also with what they withheld. Engaging with these digital reconstructions, I began to see that creating reimagined narratives based on archival material can, when done with care, serve as an ethical intervention. The attempt to humanize and particularize lives reflects an effort to resist dehumanization. It offers users an opportunity to engage with the past not solely through the retrieval of data, but through reflection, empathy, and embodied interpretation. This made me ask different questions. I began to see how researchers can use these databases not only to look for patterns or large-scale comparabilities but to interpret lived experience in ethically engaged ways.

However, from a CDH perspective, such narrative interventions must be approached with further ethical care, considering both curatorial and archival power. While interpretive narrative strategies stemming from critical fabulation and speculative biography hold the potential to reanimate these marginalized histories, my digital autoethnographic exploration and insights from conversations with Godfrey and Redfern revealed further ethical challenges and responsibilities, which will be further explored in the following sections.

6.4.2 Challenge sensationalism

A critical tension that surfaced in both projects is the risk of sensationalism. While both projects aim to engage users with difficult histories, my experience suggests that these representations sometimes bordered on the reductive, raising important ethical considerations about digital memory and historical justice. This became especially evident in my encounter with Mary Ann Hall's narrative in the *Digital Panopticon*. The title "Recidivist Thief with Poor Health" immediately confronted me, reducing her identity to a pairing of criminality and bodily decline. In my journal, I noted how this framing left little room for interpretation. Compared to the ambiguity present in Sarah Durrant's entry, Mary Ann's introduction felt predetermined, shaped more by institutional language than narrative care.

During my interview with Godfrey, he reflected on this challenge of sensationalism in the *Digital Panopticon* project. He noted that, particularly in educational contexts, students were drawn to the more "extreme" stories involving violence, even though these were not always representative of the broader convict experience. However, rather than erasing these narratives, Godfrey emphasized the importance of maintaining their presence to offer context that encourages users to look beyond the crime itself. But, regardless of Godfrey acknowledging how the platform had not initially anticipated this user behavior, he stated that this is an ethical dilemma not yet "solved". From a critical perspective, an ethical stance recognizes that historical categories are not neutral descriptors but artifacts of institutional logic that must be contextualized, not merely displayed (Berry, 2022; Risam, 2018). Without interpretive support, such classifications risk reinscribing the very systems of marginalization they aim to expose. Therefore, not having a "solution" could be embraced as an ethical discussion, where the platform could openly criticize their choices in framing the reconstructed personal narratives to encourage critical reflection and challenge how the mediated stories are interpreted by the project.

By comparison, similar ethical tensions emerged in *Ironclad Sisterhood* through its use of AI-generated images. During my interview with Redfern, he shared that the team had to develop multiple images per individual and selected them collaboratively to avoid reinforcing stereotypes. However, despite the project's commitment "...to invert the original intent of the records to create images that celebrate the humanity and agency of convict women" (*Ironclad Sisterhood*, n.d.), the platform should not only disclose that the images are AI-generated but also what biases these tools might encode. As Redfern reflected, the AI tools sometimes returned results that were inconsistent with the records, prompting the team to discard entire outputs. These experiences underscore the importance of not only

making the speculative content evident but actively educating users about the limitations of the technologies shaping their experience and understanding.

Building on these examples emphasizes the ethical stakes when digitally reimagining and mediating historical incarceration narratives and the choices made in this process. While sensational content may attract attention, it risks reducing complex lives into patterns. Therefore, to avoid sensationalistic portrayals of historically incarcerated individuals is not only about what is shown, but also about how and why. As Rouse (2019) argues, digitally constructed narratives are always shaped by the researcher's choices in design, layout, and interpretive framework, which all impact the recipient's understanding. Thus, ethical digital curation must be transparent and responsive to both archival legacies and contemporary interpretive risks.

In summary, avoiding sensationalism when constructing incarceration narratives does not mean removing parts of that history. It means approaching personal representation with context and accountability, to ensure that digital reconstructions invite critical engagement rather than passive consumption (Viola, 2023), and that they honor the complexity of lives shaped by systems of power. The implications of these decisions, who is seen, how they are framed, and what users are invited to feel, will be further explored in the discussion that follows.

6.4.3 Accessibility and affect: creating space for interpretive pause

A recurring theme in my digital autoethnographic exploration was how the structure and pace of engagement within the digital heritage platforms shaped my affective responses. While both the *Digital Panopticon* and *Ironclad Sisterhood* offer access to linked and reconstructed historical lives, it was not simply *what* I encountered that shaped my understanding, but *how* I was invited to engage with those lives. In other words, what stood out across both platforms and their narrative presentations was how both forms slowed me down, not by restraining access but by deepening engagement by their different approaches. In the *Digital Panopticon*, the reconstructed text narratives offered complexity without closure. In *Ironclad Sisterhood*, the oral storytelling fostered immediacy and presence. Together, they demonstrated that accessibility and affect are not oppositional but can be co-constitutive in how emotional resonance can be embedded into digital narrative design through pacing, tone, and transparency.

In the *Digital Panopticon*, reading the biographies slowed me down in an unexpected way. While my initial intention was not to rapidly explore or scan individual archival documents, but rather to engage thoughtfully with narratives already curated by the platform, I realized through this experience that the platform’s narrative form itself communicated an awareness beyond merely providing efficient record access for researchers or descendants. For example, the careful use of cautious language such as “likely” and “probably”, indicating that the narrative emerged from fragmented archival evidence, made me pause and reflect more deeply about the uncertainties surrounding their life. By highlighting these complexities, the *Digital Panopticon* demonstrated a purposeful approach that invites users not only to retrieve data but also to critically explore alternative

interpretations and embrace the inherent ambiguity of historical documentation, which aligns with Viola's (2023) argument on the ethical importance of revealing uncertainties and ambiguities in digital knowledge production, rather than hiding them.

In comparison with the *Ironclad Sisterhood's* platform, their approach introduced a different kind of slowness through its use of voice recordings. Listening to the audio-recorded biography of Amelia Hatfield and Margaret Southern, I felt a shift. I was no longer reading but being told a life story influenced by a prison sentence. The rhythm and tone of the narrator added a presence that text alone could not provide. I was not just reading about a woman's separation from her children, I was feeling the pauses and the weight of that loss articulated aloud. However, compared to engaging with the *Digital Panopticon*, this immersive experience felt more directed. The storytelling included affective cues, such as the narrator opening with "this really tugs on your heartstrings", which made me pause as I felt led. While I appreciated the attempt to draw me closer, it also raised ethical questions about narrative framing and emotional manipulation, in line with Kidd's (2017) questioning if it is ethically appropriate to design narratives that intentionally steer users toward specific emotional reactions. I questioned who selected these biographies and whose voice narrated them, which suggests room for a more explicitly disclosed context before user engagement. Thus, as Kelley's (2020) goodwill ethics highlights, ethical engagement demands ongoing reflexivity about how our digitally applied methods, which affect the emotional framing and narrative strategies, impact not only users' understanding but their ethical agency as interpreters of a difficult past. Therefore, while emotional immersion can humanize, transparency regarding the rationale behind affective decisions should be clearly communicated to foster responsible, informed, and critically engaged interactions.

In conclusion, it became clear that the *Digital Panopticon* and *Ironclad Sisterhood* each exemplify distinct approaches to shaping affective and reflective experiences with historical incarceration narratives. While the *Digital Panopticon* emphasized interpretive openness through speculative textual narratives, highlighting historical complexity and ambiguity, my experience with the *Ironclad Sisterhood*, characterized by emotional immediacy and relational connection through auditory narratives, created moments of affective pause that, although guided, fostered deeper connection to the lives presented. This contrast led me to reflect on how differently approached narrative reconstructions can foster ethical and reflective engagement with contested heritage. Whereas the *Digital Panopticon* created interpretive pauses by highlighting archival uncertainties, *Ironclad Sisterhood* offered a reflective space through explicit emotional framing enhanced by their affective storytelling. Experiencing these distinct approaches underscored the importance of clearly explaining to users how each project balances speculative storytelling with methodological transparency in its curatorial and narrative choices, since it is these differences in approach that require transparency for users to understand and engage with them critically.

6.4.4 Reflexivity and methodological transparency

Research transparency emerged repeatedly in my exploration as not merely a methodological merit but as a crucial ethical practice in digital humanities. According to Berry (2022), CDH emphasizes a more critically engaged and reflexive approach to how computation functions are not just tools for thought, but are infrastructures and environments that shape how knowledge is produced and experienced. This perspective extends beyond revealing the mechanics behind digital representations, it requires a continuous interrogation of the socio-technical systems behind them to examine how digital tools shape knowledge, rather than just using them without question (Berry, 2022). Thus, reflexivity and methodological transparency about these systems applied become crucial aspects of ethical accountability, which is especially important when representing complex historical narratives in a digital space.

Throughout my digital autoethnographic exploration of the *Digital Panopticon* and *Ironclad Sisterhood's* different narrative approaches, I experienced firsthand the significance of transparent methodological reflexivity. Understanding the research and re-interpretive intentions behind both projects was essential in making sense of why the narratives were reimagined in their specific ways. The transparency with which both platforms communicated their aims and methods enabled me to grasp that these narrative reconstructions were not aesthetic choices but efforts to challenge archival silences and humanize historically marginalized individuals. I came to understand that their use of reconstructive and creative biography and critical fabulation could be viewed as deliberate methods for confronting the limits of the digital archive, making the invisible visible, and offering users affective and interpretive pathways into histories often overlooked or misrepresented. Glinka et al. (2015) further support this view, arguing for interfaces that actively visualize and critique their own biases and limitations, as it calls for digital heritage platforms not only to reveal hidden archival gaps and biases but also to invite active user reflection and co-creation. This strategy also resonates with Berry's (2022) critical call for the field to be reflexive about how computational choices embed ideological positions within digital infrastructures, advocating for ongoing critical engagement with digital tools rather than passive acceptance of their outputs.

However, while both projects make their methodological frameworks publicly accessible and express an ethical awareness in their approaches, this analysis, through autoethnographic reflection and engagement, reveals that ethical care remains an ongoing process. Despite their reflexivity and critical stance, I still encountered moments of uncertainty, both emotional and interpretive. Questions about authorship, power imbalances, narrative authority, and user framing emerged even within carefully structured experiences, suggesting that ethical reflexivity cannot be fully anticipated or resolved solely through documentation.

In conclusion, research transparency and methodological reflexivity in digital humanities and heritage projects' archival animation extend beyond procedural disclosures. They represent ongoing ethical engagements, requiring projects not only to reveal their interpretative frameworks but also to actively critique their methodological and technological limitations. Embracing transparency as an ethical

stance strengthens the accountability of these initiatives, encouraging users not just to consume historical incarceration narratives but to critically interrogate and ethically reflect upon the complexities of digitally mediated representations of the past.

6.4.5 Summary of results

The analysis revealed that creating reconstructed incarceration narratives within large digital archives can itself be understood as an ethical stance, fostering deeper emotional and reflective engagement with contested heritage. It also found that presenting individual lives within broader social and institutional power structures can deepen critical engagement and interpretive understanding. Furthermore, the analysis indicates that avoiding sensationalism, designing for interpretive pause, managing historical gaps and uncertainties, and maintaining transparency in narrative authority, method, and affective framing may serve as important ethical considerations for the digital representation of incarceration narratives. These thematic findings will be further discussed in the following chapter in connection with relevant previous research.

7 Discussion

The purpose of this thesis is to examine, from an embodied perspective, how digital heritage projects depict, reinterpret, and ethically mediate incarceration narratives in a digital space. Specifically, the analysis addressed the first research question concerning what ethical reflections and challenges emerge in the digital reimagining of historical incarceration narratives when analyzed through an embodied and reflexive approach. Thus, employing a digital autoethnographic approach, with further reflections from the conducted online interviews with scholars involved in the development of the *Digital Panopticon* and *Ironclad Sisterhood* projects, the study explored how affective and reflexive modes of engagement can offer alternative ethical reflections when working within the fields of digital humanities and contested cultural heritage. Grounded in the theoretical framework of Critical Digital Humanities, the research emphasizes the importance of challenging assumptions of neutrality in digital representations, acknowledging subjectivity, interrogating systems of categorization, and resisting dominant narrative structures.

Building on the results from the analysis, the discussion in this chapter will primarily discuss the findings concerning the second research question and its sub-questions:

2. What alternative ethical strategies could be considered when animating historical narratives of incarceration?

    2.1 How can interpretive pauses support reflective engagement with digital representations of sensitive historical narratives?

    2.2 How can digital platforms avoid sensationalistic portrayals of personal incarceration histories?

    2.3 How does researcher's reflexivity and methodological transparency contribute to more ethical digital representations of personal incarceration narratives?

Without claiming definitive solutions or truths, these reflections offer context-sensitive approaches that prioritize emotional and critical engagement in studying ethical challenges. They are intended to contribute to ongoing discussions within digital humanities about how contested and vulnerable histories might be more ethically mediated through digital means, and to offer alternative strategies that may support future ethical research practices in this evolving field.

7.1 Embrace subjectivity, critical pause and reflective engagement

This study suggests that reconstructed digital incarceration narratives, through their structuring and design, can foster ethical encounters by promoting emotional and reflective engagement with contested histories. Incarceration heritage, as a difficult

form of cultural heritage, involves confronting systemic violence, social exclusion, and marginalized identities (see section 3.2). My digital autoethnographic exploration of the *Digital Panopticon* and *Ironclad Sisterhood* platforms illustrated that such narrative reconstructions enabled encounters with historical individuals as situated subjects embedded within broader social and institutional contexts. However, as Putnam (2016) underscores, digital access alone does not guarantee more objective or truthful interpretations. Also, archival projects that use advanced digital tools to collect, analyze, and share historical materials can still fall into the trap of imagining history as complete and fully knowable (Dobson, 2029). In this digital space, Godfrey (2016) similarly cautions that searchable biographical databases, while expanding access to historical information, can risk ruin-fatigue, flattening the complexity of lived experiences and facilitating emotional detachment. Carbajal and Caswell (2021; see also Berry, 2022; Viola, 2023) likewise stress that digital archives are not neutral repositories but are embedded within power structures that can either amplify or erase marginalized voices, advocating for reflexive and participatory practices prioritizing critical engagement rather than mere technological achievement. The empirical analysis presented in this study demonstrates how narrative reconstructions and digital storytelling can counter norms and symbolic annihilation by situating incarcerated individuals as relational historical agents rather than abstract criminalized figures. The affective, interpretive engagement fostered by these digital narratives was especially impactful. Rather than static representations, the fragmented, ambiguous structures of these stories invited reflection and interpretive openness. The platform's design strategies, such as emphasizing gaps, contextualizing uncertain trajectories, and resisting narrative closure, facilitated affective attachments beyond reductive criminal frameworks (Godfrey, 2016; Kidd, 2017).

Moreover, previous research has recognized that traditional modes of incarceration memorialization often prioritize architectural preservation over lived experience (Spillane, 2024). Spillane's (2024) emphasis on the ethical importance of digital archival practices that foster public memory through personal, non-anonymous narratives, revealing the humanity and inner lives of incarcerated individuals rather than reducing them to administrative data, parallels the strategies employed by the *Digital Panopticon* and *Ironclad Sisterhood*, where narrative reconstruction serves as a counterpoint to the erasures of historical experience typically produced by archival systems. In line with this discussion, Presner (2016) further critiques algorithmic structures in digital heritage that aestheticize emotional complexity, arguing that metadata-driven interfaces often distance users from personal histories and trauma. In my own engagements, deliberate design choices such as slowing interaction and sustaining interpretative ambiguity emerged as essential for fostering ethical encounters. Without such careful approaches, digital representations of incarcerated individuals risk transforming complex historical lives into easily consumable data points, reinforcing the systemic logics they seek to critique. Thus, by embedding narrative reconstructions that encourage interpretive pause, highlight silences, and foster relational engagement, projects like the *Ironclad Sisterhood* and the *Digital Panopticon* actively participate in rethinking digital heritage, not merely as information access, but as a critical mediation of contested, sensitive pasts.

These findings align closely with broader scholarly debates about ethical challenges in digitally representing sensitive historical materials. As Bauer (2023) emphasizes, digitally expanded access fundamentally reshapes ethical responsibilities previously confined within archival institutions. Bruce-Lockhart and Akande (2024) further caution that archival records documenting incarcerated individuals were rarely created with the consent of the individuals documented and must therefore be treated with heightened ethical sensitivity. Their emphasis on sustaining the person-ness of archival subjects, ensuring they are not reduced to disembodied documents, provides an important framework for understanding the stakes of digital reconstruction practices. This imperative to preserve human dignity within digital archives can be accomplished by acknowledging gaps, exclusions, and silences inherent in any historical record (Dobson, 2019) and foregrounding relational contexts rather than definitive closure. As my digital autoethnographic encounters illustrated, affective, slow, and fragmented narrative structures enabled a critical form of engagement rather than static observation. This suggests that carefully reconstructed narratives can function as ethical responses to the risks identified by Bruce-Lockhart and Akande (2024) and Bauer (2023), mitigating the risk for misrepresenting vulnerable historical subjects.

It is, however, important to emphasize that ethical responsibilities do not vanish because the individuals represented in historical records are long deceased. Representations of marginalized lives continue to shape collective memory, influence descendant communities, and can either reinforce or challenge historical injustices, long after the individuals themselves have passed. As Spillane (2024) notes, "...avoiding inflicting new harms on past victims of state custody is critical to an ethical practice of modern historical scholarship. However, the protection of privacy and the avoidance of harm should not result in the erasure of historical experience" (p. 90). As further highlighted by Nilsson Stutz (2023), "As heritage professionals our role is not to silence the present or the past, but to support an intellectual space for their relationship to be examined and interrogated." (p. 13). In line with how Bruce-Lockhart and Akande (2024) advocate for research practices that prioritize ethical responsibility over unrestricted access through contextual framing. Therefore, to not erase personal experiences but balance the integrity of the sensitive personal data, ethical sensitivity must persist even when contemporary data privacy protections no longer legally apply after death. The digital projects examined in this study consciously embody such ethical responsibility through interpretive and reflexive approaches, emphasizing subjectivity and contextual awareness even in the absence of formal privacy protections. Without such reflexivity, digital platforms risk perpetuating historical harms by not embracing the subjectivity and context of why and how these narratives are created. Thus, recognizing the persistence of ethical care beyond death underscores the critical need for humanizing, nuanced approaches to digital heritage representation.

Taken together, these findings suggest that reconstructed incarceration narratives that sustain ambiguity, interface design choices that encourage reflective rather than frictionless engagement, and a methodological commitment to relational, human-centered interpretation can foster ethically attuned digital heritage practices that align with CDH imperatives. By centering subjectivity, reflexivity, and the partiality of archival knowledge, these strategies resist the flattening tendencies of

data-driven platforms and, as demonstrated through this study's digital autoethnographic approach, invite more situated, empathetic, and ethically responsive encounters with contested pasts.

7.2 Prevent sensationalistic framing and access

As demonstrated by this thesis's empirical analysis, preventing sensationalism does not involve censoring difficult histories but instead requires careful curation, emphasizing contextual clarity and narrative transparency. While the preceding section emphasized how relational and ambiguous narratives foster ethical engagement, here I discuss the complementary necessity of addressing how digital structures and narrative framing can inadvertently perpetuate problematic representations. As Bruce-Lockhart and Akande (2024) argue, to ethically represent incarcerated lives demands more than just providing access, it necessitates critically examining how digital systems mediate these lives through labels, design choices, and institutional logics.

In the *Digital Panopticon*, even though the narratives were contextually grounded (see Figure 3), the reductive or simplified categorization, such as the one-sided labels and inconsistently framed entries, generated caution during my engagement. This experience illustrates what Berry (2022) discusses regarding the role of digital humanities in reproducing institutional, political, and normative structures through digital technologies. Berry (2022) instead advocates for a critical approach that highlights how researchers not only should build digital projects but also deconstruct them, critically examining the underlying values, biases, and power structures embedded in their digital infrastructures. Similarly, Glinka et al. (2015) emphasize that the categories employed in digital heritage projects are not neutral but actively shaped by particular value systems. They advocate for digital interfaces that employ dynamic and flexible categorizations to create new contexts and semantic relationships (Glinka et al., 2015). Thus, without further context in connection to these reconstructions, such titles and framings risk reinforcing the stigmatizing perspectives embedded in the archival systems they should instead critique.

Compared to my experiences from the *Ironclad Sisterhood,* similar ethical tensions emerged. The use of AI-generated portraits raised questions about representational bias and speculative truth. Despite the project's care in collaborative image selection and contextual framing of their methodology, Redfern noted that some AI outputs were discarded for reinforcing stereotypes. Yet, the site offers no clear disclosure of the speculative nature of the digital tools used to create the portraits. This gap, while not intended to deceive, limits users' capacity for critical reflection. As Rouse (2019) and Carbajal and Caswell (2021) emphasize, transparency about technological mediation is crucial to prevent digital storytelling from reinforcing problematic symbolic patterns by treating technology as a neutral medium of truth. Additionally, the audio narration created by the *Ironclad Sisterhood*, while affectively engaging, sometimes felt directive rather than open-ended. This resonates with Macdonald's (2022) critique of immersive heritage experiences, where compelling emotional cues can override critical engagement if the user is

"taken over" by the experience without understanding its constructed nature. In this context, authority transparency becomes an important ethical consideration, not to erase emotion, but to ensure that its application invites reflection rather than emotional direction.

In conclusion, to prevent sensationalistic portrayals, digital heritage projects should disclose their narrative strategies and technological processes, embrace complexity, remain open about affective and interpretive intentions, and actively encourage user reflection on the underlying motivations and implications of their narrative choices.

7.3 Incorporate methodological reflexivity to reflect on positionality, speculation, and embedded biases

While the previous sections have focused on the ethical reflections that emerged from my embodied and subjective engagement with the platforms, it is equally important to acknowledge the limitations of my positionality and how these shaped what remained less visible to me during the autoethnographic process (Gibbs, 2018). Without the insights shared during the interviews, I may not have fully recognized some of the ethical complexities embedded in the digital reconstruction of incarceration narratives. For instance, while my engagement surfaced questions around emotional framing and interpretive openness, I initially overlooked the deeper implications of how archival structures can reinscribe colonial, racialized, and gendered power. It was Godfrey's reflections during our interview and through the *Digital Panopticon* webpage titled "The Ethics of Digital Data on Convict Lives", where the platform critically acknowledge how they also reproduce the racist, gendered, and imperialist categories of the nineteenth-century British state, that led me to more deeply consider the project's own positionality. This moment clarified that transparency in curatorial and archival choices is not only a critical methodological but ethical practice.

This process aligns with what Östman and Turtiainen (2016) describe as an ethics that is not static or prescriptive but reflexive and negotiated throughout the research process. Their call for self-reflexive and evolving ethical frameworks is relevant in this case for researchers working in emotionally charged and historically sensitive contexts. This thesis's digital autoethnographic approach with online interviews, allowed for a form of ethical discussion, where my experiential responses were complemented and challenged by the scholars' critical reflections. This methodological interplay not only broadened the scope of ethical inquiry but also exemplified the kind of adaptive, context-sensitive ethics Östman and Turtiainen (2016) advocate for. In this way, the study embraced an alternative form of ethical reflection, attuned to the interpretive, embodied, and affective dimensions of digitally presenting and reconstructing incarceration narratives.

The inclusion of interviews was therefore not only a complement to my subjective engagement but a way to open space for more dialogical ethical reflection. As Gibbs (2018) notes, reflexivity involves making visible how one's position influences knowledge production. In this context, the interviews became a critical mirror, reflecting back the assumptions in my engagement, while revealing ethical

dimensions that might otherwise have remained obscured. Thus, projects like the *Digital Panopticon* and *Ironclad Sisterhood* demonstrate that openly acknowledging positionality and interpretive strategies when working with speculative reconstructions, storytelling, and archival gaps is not simply a research best practice but an ethical imperative. As Boyles (2018) suggests, curatorial strategies that both foreground marginalized voices and make their interpretative construction visible invite more reflective and responsible modes of engagement.

This act of research transparency, in recognizing the limitations and ideological biases of archival structures, is an active ethical stance that reorients users toward critical interpretation. This reflects a post-authentic approach that resists the illusion of applying digital methods and tools as immaterial copies of originals, but as complex, interpretive entities that carry consequences (Viola, 2023).

Therefore, the significance of speculative biography and transparent reconstruction lies not just in how narratives are written, but in how they invite users into a shared interpretative space. When clearly framed, speculation can be a method of restoring dignity and narrative agency to marginalized lives without masking embedded biases. However, this only becomes possible when digital heritage projects continuously reflect on their own positionality, not just in academic documentation, but through interface design and storytelling strategies that prioritize user awareness and interpretation. In this sense, my own experience becomes part of this ethical dialogue. What I missed as a user underscores how easily critical framing can be overlooked when not made central to the experience. Thus, ethical practices in this context must not only consider which stories are told but also how, why, and through what frameworks they are mediated.

7.4 Limitations and suggestions for future research

One of the main limitations of this study is that its approach is grounded in a singular, situated perspective, that of a digital humanities master's student engaging through digital autoethnography. While this subjective method enabled a deep, embodied exploration of emotional and ethical reflections on digitally mediated incarceration narratives, it also necessarily limited the breadth of perspectives captured. As such, the interpretations presented here are difficult to further generalise, rather, they offer critical and experiential reflections shaped by my positionality, methodological choices, and theoretical framing.

The time-intensive nature of this method also represents a limitation, especially when considering its application within larger digital humanities initiatives. Following Cooper and Lilyea's (2022) guidance on conducting digital autoethnography, I engaged in processes of self-observation, journaling, emotional reflection, and interpretive writing. This was further combined with the logistical demands of arranging, conducting, and analyzing semi-structured interviews with project scholars. For digital humanities and heritage teams, whether internal or external to the project, employing such labor-intensive methods into research and development cycles would require further planning and dedicated resources. Nevertheless, this approach demonstrates that embodied and subjective understandings can contribute meaningful ethical insights into how digital heritage

platforms represent vulnerable historical subjects, offering alternative ways to care for and critically engage with contested pasts. As Staidum (2022) suggests, digital autoethnography reveals how researchers' bodily and emotional responses to digital tools and interfaces can disrupt assumptions of neutrality in digital systems. Thus, by embedding personal reflection into digital inquiry, scholars and students can interrogate their own positionality, how platforms mediate access to the past, condition interpretive experience, and reproduce or challenge dominant power structures.

Furthermore, while the interviews added significant depth to my digital autoethnographic findings, the study included only a limited number of voices and did not include broader scholarly, user, or community engagement. Future research could extend this work through collaborative focus groups or interdisciplinary user studies, comparing interpretive and ethical strategies across multiple digital platforms. This would allow for a richer comparison of how different tools, methods, narrative framings, and ethical considerations are experienced by scholars and users from diverse academic, cultural, and social backgrounds. Given the digital humanities' inherently interdisciplinary nature, such comparative research could help advance evolving conversations around the ethics of representing complex and vulnerable histories in digital form.

Another limitation concerns the absence of formal engagement with legal data protection frameworks (see section 2.4). While this study focused on narratives of individuals who are long deceased and thus not subject to privacy law protections, it did not explore how embodied, self-reflexive research methods could be integrated within ethical and legal structures governing research involving living participants. Future research might explore how the deeply personal and affective lens offered by a netographical approach can be combined with compliance demands, contributing to more adaptive ethical frameworks that recognize the complex, situated nature of historical research in the digital age.

Furthermore, my limited background knowledge of research ethics and ethical frameworks inevitably shaped the depth and scope of my reflections. My interpretations were necessarily filtered through my own evolving understanding of research ethics, shaped by my background as a digital humanities student rather than an ethics or legal scholar. While I approached these issues with critical care, future work involving interdisciplinary collaboration with legal scholars, ethicists, and data governance experts could help deepen and refine ethical assessments in this context. However, despite these limitations, this thesis demonstrates the potential of combining digital autoethnography with semi-structured interviews as an alternative way to discuss ethical challenges. Future research may continue to explore how embodied and interpretive strategies can be ethically integrated into digital humanities and heritage work as the field evolves.

7.5 Summary

In examining the outcomes of this study, this discussion has highlighted the strengths and limitations of reflexive, embodied analysis and engagement with digital incarceration narratives. The findings illustrate how digital autoethnography,

when combined with interviews, can surface ethical complexities in the reconstruction and mediation of difficult historical narratives. At the same time, this approach is shaped by the researcher's positionality and time constraints, making generalisations difficult. Nevertheless, this approach offers opportunities for future research and experimentation in how to study digital ethical strategies with difficult histories. The conclusion that follows shortly summarises the thesis and its broader implications.

8 Conclusion

This thesis set out to explore what alternative ethical considerations and strategies emerge when reimagined historical incarceration narratives are created and experienced through digital means. Through a digital autoethnographic approach and online interviews, I analyzed the *Digital Panopticon* and *Ironclad Sisterhood* platforms to critically study ethical challenges from an embodied and reflective perspective. Grounded in the theoretical framework of Critical Digital Humanities, this thesis examined the ways animated archival narratives of contested pasts can draw focus to subjectivity, expose systems of power imbalances, and offer alternative ways of engaging with contested heritage.

The empirical findings suggest that digital reconstructions of incarcerated lives carry both ethical potential and risk. Designing for interpretive pause, avoiding sensationalistic framing, addressing historical gaps and uncertainties, and maintaining transparency in narrative authority, methodology, and emotional framing were identified as potential strategies for fostering ethical and reflective engagement with incarceration narratives. Conversely, the study also found that ethical tensions persist around representation, positionality, speculative truth, and categorisation. By bringing my embodied experiences into dialogue with project practitioners, the study showed that ethical engagement is not a fixed checklist, but an evolving process shaped by transparency, reflexivity, and situated care.

One of the key takeaways from this study is the recognition that presenting and reimagining individual incarceration narratives within broader social and institutional power structures can deepen critical engagement and interpretive understanding. Both projects examined in this thesis demonstrated that it is possible to reimagine historical incarceration narratives as an affective, critical space that centres both the silences of history and the responsibilities of representation. However, to achieve this, ethical digital heritage work should actively interrogate how historical narratives are framed, how emotions are directed, and how institutional logics are replicated or resisted. This reinforces the idea, discussed in this study, that methodological reflexivity and affective awareness are not supplementary but can be understood as central to studying and creating ethical digital incarceration narratives.

Further research is needed to extend this conversation. Future studies might explore comparative work between different digital heritage projects and user groups, which could help examine how complex historical narratives are perceived and experienced from an embodied perspective across different cultural and disciplinary contexts. Additionally, research that brings in perspectives from descendants and community members could also deepen understandings of how digital humanities projects can responsibly honour the complexity of lived incarceration histories. As the field of digital humanities continues to evolve, so too should our commitment to ethical, relational, and critically engaged practices to respect vulnerable research subjects, whether deceased or living.

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Appendix A

Interview guide conducted on 13 March 2025, with Andrew Redfern, Project Coordinator, Ironclad Sisterhood.

1. In your words, what inspired the creation of the Ironclad Sisterhood project, and what are its primary goals?

2. How would you describe the team's main ethical challenges when designing and developing the project?

3. Were or are there any ethical guidelines or frameworks that shape how the project represents and shares these personal life stories?

   Follow-up question:
   To further on that, were there any challenges in applying critical fabulation in this process?

4. Were or are there any challenges related to language, categorization, or visual mediation of the women represented?

5. Given the project's use of creative reimagination, how do you balance historical accuracy with speculative storytelling and visual display?

6. Was user feedback incorporated, and if so, how did it influence the platform's design?

7. How have people responded to the life stories presented in the project?

   Follow-up question:
   Have there been any particular insights from these interactions?

8. Are there any lessons learned from this project that you believe future digital heritage projects should consider when working with sensitive historical narratives?

9. Is there anything we have not covered that you feel is important to mention?

Appendix B

Interview guide conducted on 24 March 2025, with Barry Godfrey, Principal Investigator, the Digital Panopticon.

1. In your words, what inspired the creation of the Digital Panopticon project, and what are its primary goals?

2. How would you describe the team's main ethical challenges when designing and developing the project?

3. Were there any ethical guidelines or frameworks that shaped how the project represents and shares these personal life stories?

4. Were there any challenges related to language, categorization, or visual mediation of the individuals represented when reconstructing “Convict lives” using the Digital Panopticon website?

5. Was user feedback incorporated, and if so, how did it influence the platform’s design?

6. How have people responded to the life stories presented in the project?

   Follow-up question:
   Were there any particular insights from these interactions?

7. Are there any lessons learned from this project that you believe future digital heritage projects should consider when working with sensitive historical narratives?

   Follow-up question:
   From what you just described, were there any specific challenges being transparent in this huge project?

8. Is there anything we have not covered that you feel is important to mention?